

Pols 310 Deconstructing Decolonization

Numbered Transcript

POLS 310 • Dr. Nigel Biggar

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Lecture 1: Decolonization Story

At a glance — Nigel Biggar frames the six-part series and his aim: not to defend empire wholesale but to weigh the historical record honestly. He recounts the 2017 backlash to his 'Ethics and Empire' project, the post-2020 conflation of colonialism with slavery, and argues the American Revolution itself belongs within the story of European colonialism rather than standing cleanly against it.

- 1.1 Welcome, everybody, to this 6-part series of lectures. The title I've given to the series is: Deconstructing Decolonization. I will explain what is meant by decolonization, and you will observe how I deconstruct it. This first lecture is introductory.
- 1.2 In early December 2017, just over 5 years ago, my wife and I were at the London Heathrow Airport, about to fly off to Germany to celebrate our wedding anniversary. Just before departing for the departure gate, I couldn't resist checking my email just one last time, as one can't resist. When I did that, I discovered in my inbox a message from the University of Oxford's Public Affairs Directors. At that time, I was teaching at the University of Oxford. I clicked on the email, and what I found was a communication that told me that my Ethics and Empire project had become the target of an online denunciation by a group of students, followed, I should add, by a reassurance from the university that it had risen to defend my right to run such a thing. So began a public row that raged for the best part of a month.
- 1.3 4 days after I flew, the eminent imperial historian who had conceived the project with me, abruptly resigned. Within a week of the 1st online denunciation, 2 further ones appeared, this time manned by professional academics, the 1st comprising 58 colleagues at Oxford, the 2nd, about 200 academics from around the world. For over a fortnight, my name was in the press every day.
- 1.4 What had I done to deserve this unexpected attention? 3 things—in late 2015 and early 2016, I'd offered a qualified defense of the late 19th-century imperialist and founder of the famous scholarship scheme, Cecil Rhodes. I'd done this during the 1st 'Rhodes Must Fall' campaign in Oxford. Then 2nd, in late November 2017, I published a column in the London Times newspaper in which I referred approvingly to Bruce Gilley's controversial article, The Case for Colonialism— you'll understand why it's controversial. I argued that the British, I am British, we British, have reason to feel pride as well as shame in our imperial past—note: pride as well as shame. A few days later, 3rd, I finally got round to publishing an online account of the Ethics and Empire project, whose first conference had, in fact, been held the previous July.
- 1.5 Contrary to what most critics seem to think, this project is not designed to defend the British Empire or even empire in general. Rather, it aims to select and analyze evaluations of empire from ancient China to the modern period in order to understand and reflect on the ethical terms in which contemporaries viewed empires they

inhabited. How did the ancient Chinese view ancient Chinese Empire? How did medieval Muslims view medieval Muslim Empire?

- 1.6 A classic instance of such an evaluation is St Augustine's City of God, St Augustine writing in the early 400s AD. It's mainly a defense of Christianity against pagan critics, but it involves a critical reading of Roman Empire from a Christian point of view. Nonetheless, Ethics and Empire—being aware that the imperial form of political organization was common across the world and throughout history until the 1960s—the project does not assume that empire is always and ever were wicked. It does assume that the history of empires should inform, positively as well as negatively, the foreign policy of Western states today. Anyway, that's how I stumbled inadvertently into the culture war over colonialism. I wasn't expecting it. It came to me. I just said what I thought to be true.
- 1.7 2 1/2 years later, in May 2020, the killing of George Floyd by a white policeman in Minneapolis was used by the Black Lives Matter organization to dominate public attention in the United States. Swiftly exported across the Atlantic to Britain, BLM fused with the Rhodes Must Fall campaign which had arrived there from South Africa, and it promoted decolonization from a marginal academic theory into a widespread cultural movement.
- 1.8 Since then, it's become common in Britain to talk of colonialism and slavery in the same breath as if they were identical. Any association with the slave trade or slavery, no matter how indirect or tangential, has become sufficient to destroy a once-famous reputation. And institutions of all kinds, from schools to universities to museums to government development agencies, have fallen over themselves to sever any visible connection with Britain's colonial past. Statues have been boarded up. Street names have been changed. Plaques have been removed. School reading lists have been revised. University courses have been dropped. Suddenly, decolonization has become all the rage.
- 1.9 In this series of lectures, I'm going to argue that the decolonization movement is almost entirely wrong-headed. It's wrong-headed because it rests on a set of falsehoods, partly about the present, mostly about the past.
- 1.10 Now, the relevant past is most obviously the history of those European countries that ran overseas empires until shortly after the Second World War, not least my own country, Britain, which ran the largest empire. But it also involves the history of the United States. In case that's not immediately obvious to Americans, let me explain. There was a time when many people, at least in Europe, thought that empire was a good thing, ending endemic intertribal warfare and bringing the benefits of humanitarian emancipation, modern science and technology, and moral and religious enlightenment, to the benighted places and peoples of the world.

- 1.11** Those like me, whose parents were born before 1914, my father was born in 1913, are separated from that era of imperial self-confidence by a single generation. By the end of the First World War, however, several mighty stars in the imperial firmament had fallen, and the future of those that remained looked insecure. Moreover, the sheer fact of imperial disillusion, whether Ottoman or Austro-Hungarian or German or Russian, was given moral impetus when at the 1919 Paris Peace Conference, Woodrow Wilson, President Woodrow Wilson, lent American weight to the notion that nations possess a right to self-determination.
- 1.12** Now, Wilson's attitude was not at all surprising. After all, the US was born out of a struggle to throw off the constraints of the British Empire. According to the conventional patriotic story, the War of 1775-1783 was one of national freedom against imperial tyranny. Yet the whole truth of the American quest for independence is not as simple as the anti-imperialist narrative would have us believe. What was the tyranny supposedly at issue? Answer: monarchy with absolutist unconstitutional tendencies, manifested in the arbitrary imposition of intolerable taxes, and enforced by brutal military coercion. Here we have the imperialist archetype of empire. But is this an accurate description of the actual behavior of King George III and the British government in that era? Or is this archetype, in fact, a stereotype?
- 1.13** Now, it's true that weak politicians in Britain believed that the King was subverting the Constitution by using royal patronage to control—that is, buy—Parliament, and that this reading of events influenced their allies in colonial America. It is true that, in 1765, the Grenville Ministry unilaterally imposed direct taxation upon the colonies, most famously via the Stamp Act, which was unprecedented. It's true that the American colonists did not have direct representation in Westminster. It's true that the behavior of British troops in and around Boston on the eve of war was sometimes provocative and sometimes brutal. All that is true.
- 1.14** But the following is also true. Contemporary historians judge that Whig anxiety about another resurgence of absolute monarchy in England was altogether overwrought. The buying of political influence by the Crown was a serious problem, but it fell a long way short of what the word "tyranny" connotes. Moreover, the Grenville taxes had been levied to help defray the costs of the French and Indian War of 1754-1763, which had secured the English colonies in America, but at the cost of doubling the British national debt and quintupling the expense of colonial defense and administration. In the event, the taxation was short-lived. Thanks to a combination of American resistance, including mob violence, British mercantile lobbying, and a change in Ministry, the Stamp Act was repealed the following year. Besides, that issue rose and fell 9 years before the outbreak of war in 1775.
- 1.15** The infamous customs duty on tea, the likes of which had long been used by the imperial government to raise revenue, that was quite different. It had long been used. It wasn't unprecedented. On the matter of representation, it was true that the colonies

didn't elect members to the British Parliament. But they did have agents in London who recruited British MPs to their cause. So American views were not unrepresented. And even if they had been represented directly, they wouldn't necessarily have prevailed.

- 1.16** As for the military abuses, 18th-century soldiery was generally unruly and brutal. Come the war, even American patriots did atrocious things. Yet the most famous instance of British military brutality is surely the Boston Massacre, when bloodthirsty redcoats gunned down innocent civilians. Except that as historians now acknowledge, the redcoats weren't so bloodthirsty, nor the civilians quite so innocent.
- 1.17** To this picture, 2 further factors need to be added. First—one of the manifestations of tyranny against which the colonists reacted was the British granting of religious tolerance to Roman Catholics in Quebec in 1774. Since at that time, Roman Catholicism was equated with political tyranny, this was taken as a further sign of the absolutist tendencies of British government. In fact, it was nothing of the sort. The granting of tolerance was merely an act of political prudence, and none the worse for that, aimed at enabling the Catholic French to live peaceably under British rule.
- 1.18** Second—in the aftermath of the French and Indian War, the British had promised Native Americans that colonists would not invade and settle the land west of the Appalachians. To the colonists, of course, this was another manifestation of tyranny, a deeply unwelcome constraint upon what they saw as their natural right to expand their domestic imperial, expand beyond the Appalachians. A constraint, that is to say, on their domestic imperial imperative.
- 1.19** Urging the claims of the US upon the Mississippi Valley against Spain, James Madison, the chief architect of the US Constitution, wrote to Lafayette in 1785 as follows: "Nature has given the use of the Mississippi to those who may settle on its waters as she gave the US their independence. Nature seems on all sides to be reasserting those rights which have so long been trampled on by tyranny and bigotry. If the United States were to become parties to the occlusion of the Mississippi, they would be guilty of treason against the very laws under which they obtained and hold their national existence." On the natural moral claims of the Native Americans, Madison was silent. So that then, I suggest to you, is the more morally complicated story of the war by which the American colony seceded from the British Empire.
- 1.20** To summarize that conflict as a battle between colonial liberty and imperial tyranny does not begin to do the details justice, and it misleads far more than it informs. Yes, the British imperial center was remote, both in miles and increasingly in culture. Yes, the representation of the colonists and their interests in the Imperial lawmaking and tax-imposing Parliament was only indirect and so weaker than it could and arguably should have been. But the principle that the primary beneficiaries of the French and Indian War should bear a fair share of its costs is, I think, incontrovertible.

- 1.21** The practice of external taxation by which the government sought to realize that principle had long been established. What is more, in this case, it was the British Empire that upheld the religious liberty of Roman Catholics to practice their religion in Quebec. It was the empire that upheld the political liberty of Native Americans not to be invaded. In the latter case, the British Empire constrained the American colonists' own imperial ambitions westward, and their frustration at that constraint was one of the main causes of the American War of Independence.
- 1.22** My main point here is to say that the United States belongs to the history of European colonialism, not simply as an opponent, which it was, but also as an active participant. The decolonizing critique is relevant to Americans as well as to Britons, Canadians, Australians, and New Zealanders, and to the Portuguese, the Spanish, the French, the Dutch, and to a lesser extent, the Danes and Belgians. That's my main point. It's relevant, not just to the British.
- 1.23** What is the decolonizing critique? In October of last year, October 2022, the acting vice Chancellor of the University of Cambridge in England, Dr. Anthony Freeling, made a confession which was widely reported in the press. He confessed that he is baffled by decolonization. "The word," he said, "has been misused to such an extent that I don't think, if I'm honest, I can give an accurate definition." I sympathize with his bafflement, as do I strongly suspect millions of others. And that's because decolonization can mean a variety of different things, some of which make quite good sense, but others, very bad sense indeed. The bad ones smuggle themselves into university departments under cover of the good.
- 1.24** The original and most natural home of decolonization is in former European colonies. There it can mean something entirely reasonable. For example, in 1986, the Kenyan novelist and playwright, Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, published a book with the title *Decolonizing the Mind*. In this book, he argued that African literature should be written in African languages, such as his own Kikuyu. Why? So that Africans can recover a sense of self-respect and stop being enthralled to the assumption that whatever comes out of Europe is better. To which I think the only sensible response is, well, yes, of course. Yes, of course.
- 1.25** When translated out of its original post-colony context and into contemporary Britain or elsewhere, decolonization can still make some good sense. It can mean correcting the neglect in school curricula of the history of immigration and the contribution of immigrants to the UK. Or it can mean that important texts have been excluded from reading lists in schools and universities just because of prejudice against the race of their authors. If it is true that the history of immigration and the multicultural reality of Britain has been neglected, and if it is true that important texts had been excluded just because of the color of the author's skin, then curricula should indeed be decolonized. If those things are true and have been shown to be true, in my own limited experience,

those things are assumed to be true more than it be shown to be true. But so far, I think so much good sense.

- 1.26** Less reasonable, however, is the opposition of some decolonizers to Eurocentricity and their insistence on shifting attention to non-European histories and cultures. On the contrary, it seems to me a certain Eurocentricity in the education system of a country like Britain is entirely justified. Britain is not anywhere. It is located in northwest Europe. It has a particular history and it has developed particular institutions and traditions. It's vitally important, therefore, that British school education, at least, should focus on helping budding citizens understand the immediate cultural and political environment in which they stand and for which they're about to become directly responsible. Of course, once at university, students can throw off Eurocentricity to their hearts' content and immerse themselves completely in African culture, Indian history, and Chinese language, if they so wish.
- 1.27** Equally unreasonable, I think, is claim that school and university reading lists should contain that ethnic diversity of authors so that an ethnic diversity of students can identify with them. I say this because it seems to me manifestly untrue that people of a certain race can only relate to, understand, be inspired by, and learn from someone of the same race. For example, white Europeans and Britons have been admiring the Semitic Jesus for two millennia. Jesus did not have a white skin. And the Indian Mahatma Gandhi for over a century. Nor did Gandhi have a white skin.
- 1.28** And judging by the occasion, at a college dinner in Oxford about 10 years ago, when I found myself surrounded by a troupe of Shakespearean actors from Kabul, Afghanistan, it seems that Afghans are perfectly capable of appreciating England's most famous dramatist. Most happily, we really are not intellectually imprisoned in racial silos. We can transcend our own race to appreciate what's true and beautiful and good about another culture. All of us do that most of the time.
- 1.29** Not only unreasonable, I think, but positively dangerous is the decolonizing view that identifies reason, scientific method, and the liberal values of tolerance and free speech as Eurocentric, and therefore, manifestations of an oppressive Western hegemony that deserves to be pulled down. How much good sense does that make, do you think, to the ethnically Chinese students who put their lives and liberty at risk in fighting for liberal rights to free speech in Hong Kong? And what exactly is the alternative to reason and tolerance other than arbitrary force? This anti-rational decolonization is the handmaid of authoritarian politics.
- 1.30** Some kinds of decolonization, I think, make good sense. Some, not so good. But there is one kind in particular that should worry us especially, I think. In discussing it, I'm going to focus on what it says about Britain, its present and its past, because that's what I know best. But what it says about Britain also applies more broadly, because I take Britain here to be a proxy for the West. Why do I take that to be the case? Partly because Britain was the dominant European and European-founded country for more

than a century after 1815, until roughly the First World War. And up until 1939, it was still the leading European global power.

- 1.31** During the Second World War, to defeat Nazi Germany and Imperial Japan, the United States assumed leadership of the Allies, most of whom were the exception of Soviet Russia, most of whom were members of the British Empire. In that war, the British ceded a number of imperial military bases around the world, which the US uses to this day. In the subsequent Cold War, Britain, together with former colonies, such as Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, became important junior partners to the US in the continuing endeavor to save the world for liberal democracy by containing and defeating Russia and China, originally Communist, now merely autocratic. Britain's record is also, more or less, the West's record.
- 1.32** So the kind of decolonization that should worry citizens of Western countries most tells the following story: Britain is a systemically racist country. Its racism is rooted in its colonial past, which it continues to celebrate, not least in the form of public statues such as that of Cecil Rhodes on Oxford's High Street. The epitome, the essence, of this colonial past was slavery, in which Britons treated Africans as subhuman. This view of Africans as subhuman expanded into a wholesale disparagement of non-white cultures and the forcible imposition of British culture onto unwilling non-white peoples, which amounted to genocide.
- 1.33** Therefore, so the story goes, we need to exorcise, to expel, this lingering racist mentality by repudiating Britain's colonial heritage. Indeed, we need to rectify the injustice done to colonialism's victims by making reparations for its sins to their living descendant. That's the story that comprises what I'll call the cultural revolutionary form of decolonization. It's this that smuggles itself into university departments under cover of more reasonable ideas. And as I'll explain, I think it's a false story. False because every one of its main assumptions is wrong.
- 1.34** Now, why I think that, I'll explain in a moment. But first, let me tell you why I think you should care. In Britain and perhaps elsewhere, there are lots of people on the political left and some on the political right who think that the present culture wars are either a mendacious distraction or a futile distraction. I couldn't disagree more strongly. In my view, the colonial culture war is culturally crucial. Since politics is downstream of culture, it is politically crucial, too. Why? Because what's at stake is present, not past. What's at stake is faith in the liberal West and its global dominance at a time of threat from aggressively illiberal states such as Putin's Russia and Xi's China.
- 1.35** Observe, first of all, that the decolonizers show no interest at all in non-Western empires. An empire is a single state that contains a variety of peoples, one of which is dominant. That's my general definition of what an empire is. As a form of political organization, it's been around for millennia and has appeared on every continent. The Assyrians were doing empire in the Middle East over 4,000 years ago. They were followed by the Egyptians, the Babylonians, and the Persians. In the 6th century BC, the

Carthaginians established a series of colonies around the Mediterranean. Then came the Athenians, followed by the Romans, and after them, the Byzantine rump. Empire first appeared in China in the 3rd century BC, and despite periodic collapses, still survives to this day.

- 1.36** From the 7th century AD, Muslim Arabs invaded east as far as Afghanistan and west as far as central France. In the 15th century, empire proved very popular. The Ottomans were doing it in Asia Minor, the Mongols in the Indian subcontinent, the Incas in South America, and the Aztecs in Mesoamerica. Further north, 3 centuries later, the Comanche extended their imperial sway over much of what is now Texas, while the Asante were expanding their control in West Africa. In the 1820s, King Shaka led the highly militarized Zulus in scattering other South African peoples to several of the four winds, conducting at least one exterminationist war.
- 1.37** Set in this global historical context, the emergence of European empires from the 15th century onwards is hardly remarkable. The Portuguese were first off the mark, followed by the Spanish, and then in the 16th century by the Dutch, the French, and the English. The Scots attempted in vain to join their ranks in the 1690s. The Russians did so in the 1700s, as did the newly independent Americans in the 1800s.
- 1.38** What's remarkable, however, is that the contemporary controversy about empire shows no interest at all in any of the non-European empires, past or present. It shows no interest at all, for example, in today's aggressively assertive Chinese Empire. European empires are its sole concern, and of these, above all others, the English, or as it became after the Anglo-Scottish Union in 1707, the British one—so you understand, you may not understand, until 1707, Britain didn't exist. There was England and Scotland. In 1707, the 2 kingdoms united, which is what became Britain.
- 1.39** Now, the reason for this focus, I think, is that the real target of today's decolonizers is the West, and more specifically, the Anglo-American liberal world order that has prevailed since 1945. This order is held to be responsible for the economic and political woes of what used to be called the Third World or developing world, and is now called the Global South. Allegedly, it continues to express the characteristic white supremacism and racism of the old European empires, displaying arrogant, ignorant disdain for non-Western cultures, thereby humiliating non-white peoples. It presumes to impose alien values upon them and to justify military interference in their sovereign affairs.
- 1.40** Now, I first became aware of the anti-Western motivation of the decolonizers when reading about contemporary Scottish nationalism—in spite of my accent, I am, in fact, Scottish—English mother, Scottish father—an Anglo-Scot. I have a strong interest in the issue of Scottish independence. I oppose it. I won't go into that now. But I was reading about Scottish nationalism before the referendum on independence in 2014. I discovered that there's a strong strain in Scottish nationalism which believes in the equation, Britain = empire = evil. And by empire here is meant not just Britain's imperial

past, but her present global role in supporting a liberal international order that grew out of that past and is now led by the US. According to some nationalists, therefore, for Scotland to separate from England, to disintegrate the United Kingdom, and so to undermine one of the pillars of the West would be an act of national repentance and self-purification, a rejection of that wicked Western hegemony.

- 1.41 In his 1930s novel, *A Man Without Qualities*, which was set in the decline of the Austrian Empire around the year 1900, Robert Musil wrote this, "However well-founded an order may be, it always rests in part on a voluntary faith in it. Once this unaccountable and uninsurable faith is used up, the collapse soon follows. Epochs and empires crumble no differently from business concerns when they lose credit." When they lose credit. Scottish nationalists have not only abandoned faith in Britain and the West, they actively seek to undermine it.
- 1.42 Now, I concede that if it were true, that Britain's 300-year imperial rule, a 300-year imperial career as a global power, was nothing but a litany of racism and cultural contempt, summed up in the perpetration of slavery, then far from identifying with it, we should indeed repudiate it, if it is true. We should stop trying to keep the UK united. We should stop trying to uphold the so-called liberal international order. We should stop supporting the West, if that past, if that story about the past, is true.
- 1.43 The reason why decolonization matters is because of the story it tells about Britain's past and present and of what that implies for Britain's future. And what it tells about Britain in particular, it also tells about the West in general. Since I think the story it tells is largely untrue, even fraudulent at some points, the danger that decolonization poses is that of persuading the peoples of the West to chart a course into the future that is based on a lie.
- 1.44 In 1976, the Baghdad-born Jewish historian Elie Kedourie published his book, *In the Anglo-Arab Labyrinth*. In this book, he argued against the belief that Britain had betrayed the Arabs during the First World War, a belief that had come to infect the British Foreign Office. He closes the 7th chapter of his book with this sentence, "No doubt, great powers do commit great crimes, but a great power is not always and necessarily in the wrong. And the canker of imaginary guilt, even the greatest power can ill withstand." The canker of imaginary guilt, even the greatest power can ill withstand.
- 1.45 Britain is no longer a great power, but she still is an important power, and she's an important liberal power at a time when illiberal forces in Moscow and Beijing are flexing their brutal authoritarian muscles on the battlefields of Ukraine, the streets of Hong Kong, and across the narrow water from Taiwan. The reason why cultural revolution and decolonization matters is that it threatens to infect the peoples of the West and undermine their liberal power with the canker, the cancer, of imaginary guilt. That's why I think, even if you're not British, you should care, because what's at stake is

faith in the liberal West and the self-confidence of its peoples at the time of threat from ruthlessly authoritarian states.

- 1.46** In most of what remains of this lecture, I'm going to begin to explain why the cultural revolutionary decolonizing story is, to my mind, false. Let me remind you of its main claims. Britain is a systemically racist country, and that racism is rooted in its colonial past, which it continues to celebrate. The epitome, the essence, of this colonial past was slavery, in which Britons treated Africans as as subhuman. This view of Africans as subhuman expanded into a wholesale disparagement of the cultures of non-white peoples and the unwanted imposition of British culture upon them. Therefore, the British need to exorcise, to expel, this lingering racist mentality by repudiating Britain's colonial heritage. Indeed, they need to make amends to the descendants of the victims of colonialism by offering reparations for its sins.
- 1.47** So first, then, is Britain today systemically racist? That's to say, is there a generally prevailing prejudice of white Britons against non-white Britons? Now, the issue is an empirical one. It's either true or it's false. I think there are strong reasons for doubting that claim. To begin with, there is the visible fact that in the recent government of Boris Johnson, most of those in charge of the major departments of the British State were headed by Britons of Middle Eastern, Asian, or African heritage.
- 1.48** Rishi Sunak, then Chancellor, now Prime Minister, is of Indian heritage. Priti Patel, then Home Secretary, came from East African Asian heritage. Sajid Javid, Health Secretary, Pakistani. Nadhim Zahawi, Education Secretary, Iraqi, Kwasi Kwarteng, Business Secretary, Ghanaian. Kemi Badenoch, Minister of State for Equalities, was born in Nigeria. If Britain really were systemically racist, that wouldn't have happened, and especially it would not have happened under a conservative government. Systemically racist, white supremacist countries simply do not fill the highest offices of state with members of ethnic minorities whose skin color is other than white.
- 1.49** Next, there is a witness of the March 2021 report of the UK Government's Commission on Race and Ethnic Disparities, the so-called Cred or Sewell Report. Tony Sewell was the chairman of the commissioners. Although 10 out of the 11 commissioners hailed from non-white ethnic minorities, they nevertheless argued in their report that contemporary Britain is not as a whole systemically racist, even though it contains instances of structural racism.
- 1.50** Now, the report was and is controversial, and it has been angrily dismissed by left-wing journalists and activists, often by appeal to the "lived" experience of black people. Let's just reflect on that for a moment. There is no single experience of black people. As the report demonstrates, the typical experience of Chinese Britons differs significantly from that of Nigerian Britons, which in turn differs from that of West Indian Britons. For that reason, the report urges us to stop speaking of black and minority ethnic or BAME people as if they were all the same because they're not. It urges us to stop setting the

experience of BAME people and white people over and against each other in a simplistic binary opposition.

- 1.51** The truth about racial inequalities in Britain is actually far more complicated. While West Indian Britons generally perform worse than most whites, they also perform worse than West Africans. West Indian Britons perform better than poor whites. The poor whites perform worst of all ethnic groups. You can't talk about a simple binary opposition between white and black. It's far more complicated. Moreover, there's no such thing as a single lived experience of undifferentiated black people in Britain. Moreover, lived experience is never pure. This concept of lived experience deserves some reflection. Lived experience, I suggest to you, is never cognitive bedrock, lying securely beyond critical interrogation and assessment. And that's because experience always embodies perceptions. And perceptions can be mistaken.
- 1.52** To take an extreme example, and I make an extreme example because it's one I think you all agree with, the lived experience of Nazis is that Jews are an abomination. That's how they feel, viscerally. No one here is going to say, I imagine, that what a Nazi claims is beyond interrogation or beyond criticism because it's based on perceptions that can be mistaken—in this case, are mistaken. Let me be clear, I'm not saying that those who appeal to the lived experience of black people are Nazis. I'm not saying that. What I am saying is that experience, however deeply felt, embodies perceptions, and perceptions can be wrong. They needn't be wrong, but they can be. That's why we can't take lived experience at face value. It is no final authority. It can be held to account and asked to justify itself. But even where the lived experience of non-white Britons is based on accurate perception, it represents the accurate perception of only some individuals. The Sewell report, however, looks beyond the experience of particular individuals to broadly based social-scientific data so as to ground reliable generalizations.
- 1.53** Besides, those who are ideologically inclined to dismiss Sewell should pay attention to the 2018 report of the European Union Agency of Fundamental Rights. The report was called Being Black in the EU. This found that the prevalence of racist harassment, as perceived by people of African descent, was lower in the UK than in any EU country except Malta. The prevalence of overall racial discrimination was the lowest in the UK, bar none. For those reasons, I believe that the first main claim of the cultural revolutionary decolonizing story, that Britain today is systemically racist, is not true.
- 1.54** That first decolonizing claim is an empirical one about the present. The next ones are mainly historical claims about the past, namely that slavery and the racism that justified it comprised the essence of British colonialism, and this was expressed in the wholesale disparagement of non-white cultures and the forcible imposition of alien British culture onto unwilling non-white peoples. The accusation that this disparagement and imposition amounted to genocide adds a moral claim to the historical ones. We've dealt with empirical claim about the present. I'm going to deal with historical claims about the past, but there's also a moral claim about genocide. The assessment of all

those claims will be the business of my next 3 lectures. But by way of preparing the ground for them, let me close this lecture with 3 clarifications about the terms I'm going to use.

- 1.55** First of all, there's the pair empire and colony. Now, I've already defined an empire as a single state containing a variety of peoples, one of which is dominant. A colony is not quite the same thing. A colony is a territory directly ruled by the dominant imperial people. Empire did not always involve colonization. Much of British India, for example, comprised the so-called Princely States that were largely autonomous but subject to British imperial advice or supervision. British imperial was indirect, not direct. They were never colonized in the sense of having Britons permanently take over their direct administration or settle in dominating numbers on their territory. The first clarification I want to make is empire and colony are not the same thing.
- 1.56** The 2nd pair of terms I want to clarify are similar. Imperialism and colonialism. On the whole, I try and avoid using either word because an "-ism" connotes something that's unified and coherent. It connotes an ideological system or practical unity in essence that simply does not correspond to the changing variety of things that actual empires usually were, and that the British Empire certainly was. No one woke up one sunny morning in London and said, "Let's go conquer the world." I don't suppose any empire started that way—not many. In that sense, the British Empire was not, from its inception, a coherent project, methodically developed out of some original plan. It grew up haphazardly in ad hoc response to opportunities and challenges and for a wide range of different reasons.
- 1.57** Finally, let me also explain my choice of words to denote, to refer to the peoples that met the British when they first arrived in North America, in the Caribbean, in Africa, and in Asia. As a rule, I refer to them in the first instance as "native peoples". When overuse would sound clumsy, I deploy "natives" instead. I want to make it clear that as I use it here, the word "native" does not mean, it doesn't connote cultural primitiveness. It merely means what the Latin origin of the word "native" means, someone who's born in a place. I'm a native of Scotland. That's where I was born. You're natives of Miami or the US. There's no connotation of cultural disparagement in the way I'm using the word. I could have used the word *indigenes* instead or *indigenous*. That strikes me as being more technical, less familiar, which is why I chose the word native. Also because some native people are not indigenous. When I talk about the peoples of Australia and Tasmania, however, I talk about Aborigines because that's customary and partly because, unlike most of the native peoples elsewhere, they really were the original inhabitants of the territory on which the British found them. Those are the 3 sets of terms I want to clarify for you. Empire and Colony, Imperialism and Colonialism, and then finally, what I mean by the word native or native peoples.
- 1.58** So before I close, let me just make clear that much of what I've said in this lecture has been drawn from the introduction to my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*, to be

published in February 2023. Most of the lectures that follow will be abbreviated versions of some of its chapters. If you want to explore more deeply the issues I've raised in this lecture and in the series of lectures, I refer you to that book. Thanks very much.

Lecture 2: Slavery and Emancipation

At a glance — The lecture examines slavery and its abolition, distinguishing the moral horror of the slave trade from the sweeping claim that empire equals slavery. Biggar stresses Britain's leading role in emancipation and cautions against reading present categories back onto a more tangled past.

- 2.1 Welcome back to this series of lectures—Deconstructing Decolonization—and to the second lecture, whose title is; On Slavery. The aim of this series of lectures is to deconstruct what I call the cultural revolutionary story about decolonization, to take it apart and to show how all of its main empirical, historical, and moral claims are untrue.
- 2.2 Let me remind you of how the story goes in relation to Britain, which I take to be a proxy for the West as a whole. Britain is a systemically racist country. Its racism is rooted in its colonial past, which it continues to celebrate, not least in its public statuary. The epitome, the essence, of this colonial past was slavery, in which Britons treated Africans as subhuman. This view of Africans as subhuman expanded into a wholesale disparagement of the cultures of non-white peoples and the unwanted imposition of European culture upon them—a disparagement in a position that amounted to genocide, cultural genocide. Therefore, so the story goes, the British need to exorcise, to expel, this lingering racist mentality by repudiating Britain's colonial heritage. Indeed, they need to go further and make amends to the descendants of the victims of colonialism by offering reparations for its sins.
- 2.3 Now, in my last first lecture, I briefly addressed the first claim that Britain today is a systemically racist country, and I explained why I think it false. In this lecture, I will test the claim that slavery was the essence of British colonialism and is the root of whatever racism persists in Britain today.
- 2.4 But first of all, we need to pause and think about what we mean by slavery. What is slavery? What makes slavery? Historically, there have been a variety of slaveries, various not only in their legal status and actual form, but also in their moral quality. For us, however, slavery, like torture and genocide, refers to something simply, irredeemably, and intolerably evil. What is it we have in mind? What are the features of slavery that are simply evil?
- 2.5 One feature could be hard labor. But many kinds of work are laborious, even soul-destroying in their tedium, without amounting to enslavement. Sometimes laborious work is performed under the terms of an unfair indenture or contract, to which the employee has consented only under duress. And yet an exploited employee doesn't quite make a slave. Even forced labor can fall well short of slavery. There's nothing necessarily wrong, it seems to me, with requiring members of a community, by law or custom, to spend some of their time and energy on public works or in public service. What distinguishes and specifies slavery as a simple evil we now understand it to be is not hard labor or an unfair contract or legal compulsion.

- 2.6 What specifies it is that the slave's time and employment are owned, not voluntarily under certain conditions for certain purposes and for a certain length of time, but absolutely. The slave is the slave owner's disposable property to be put to whatever use the owner decides and to be bought and sold, maybe even killed, at will. That is the pure form or paradigm of slavery, and it's the treatment of another human being as absolutely disposable property that makes it categorically worse than other forms of unjust employment.
- 2.7 Nevertheless, it is important to remember that historically, not everything that went by the name of slavery lived down to this simply evil form. In different times and places, the condition of the slave differed. Sometimes there were legal or customary constraints on what owners were permitted to do with their human property. The right to ownership was not always absolute. For example, an owner was sometimes forbidden to strike or kill his slave or obliged to grant him his freedom under certain conditions. And where a failure of proprietorial duty was liable to incur legal penalties, and where those penalties were applied, there the slave had an enforceable right, a right under law. Yet even where there were no legal constraints and no corresponding rights, slave owners whose consciences retained a measure of sensitivity may have felt morally obliged to use their legal freedom humanely, say, by not selling a slave apart from his wife and children if they could avoid it.
- 2.8 Nonetheless, when all the qualifications had been duly made, it remains the case that the slave was radically dependent upon the will of his master for his livelihood, his family, and even his life. Where that will was subject to little or no effective legal constraint, the institution of slavery was highly objectionable. Because even if it did happen to occasion decent treatment, it did happen to occasion decent treatment, it didn't secure it, and it also permitted the most dreadful abuse.
- 2.9 Slavery wasn't just various, it was also ancient. From the earliest times, victors in battle chose to enslave the vanquished rather than slaughter them. There is a late 19th-century Scottish moral philosopher, David Ritchie, who at one point makes the dangerous claim, but possibly a true one, that in human history, slavery represents a moral advance, insofar as after being beaten in battle, being enslaved was better than being slaughtered. Not much of an advance, perhaps.
- 2.10 Not only was slavery ancient, it was also universal. Across the globe, societies have employed forced labor in agriculture, mining, public works, and even as troops. All the ancient Mesopotamian civilizations practiced slavery, in one form or another, starting with Egypt in the 3rd millennium BC. To the west, around the shores of the Mediterranean Sea, the ancient Greeks, Carthaginians, and Romans followed. To the east, slavery could be found among the Chinese from at least the 7th century AD, and subsequently among the Japanese and Koreans. In the Americas, the Incas and Aztecs extracted forced labor from subject peoples, including prisoners of war, from the 15th

century AD, as did native tribes in North America. From 1750-1850, according to Pekka Hämäläinen, the Comanche ran, "the largest slave economy in the colonial Southwest."

- 2.11** From the time of Muhammad in the 600s onward, slavery was practiced throughout the Islamic world. In the 8th and 9th centuries, the Vikings supplied slave markets in Muslim Spain and Egypt with slaves from Eastern Europe and the British Isles. In the 1600, corsairs or pirates from the Barbary Coast of North Africa raided English merchant ships and even Cornish villages for slaves. One estimate has it that raiders from Tunis, Algiers, and Tripoli alone enslaved between 1 million and 1.25 million Europeans from the beginning of the 16th century to the middle of the 18th century. Another estimate reckons that the Muslim slave trade as a whole, which lasted until 1920, transported about 17 million slaves, mostly African, exceeding by a considerable margin the approximately 11 million shipped by Europeans across the Atlantic.
- 2.12** Meanwhile, Africans had been busy enslaving other Africans for centuries, mostly by capturing them in war or raids, sometimes taking them in lieu of debt. Often, slaves were destined for profitable export, first to Roman markets, then to Arab ones. But they also had their local uses, which included supplying victims for human sacrifices. The practice of human sacrifice in West Africa was attested as early as the 10th century by Ibn al-Hawqal and by Europeans 400 years later.
- 2.13** Human sacrifices served a variety of purposes. Sometimes to appease the gods, but more often to supply a deceased master with servants in the afterlife, to make a conspicuous display of extravagant wealth, and to intimidate onlookers. Although wives, favorites, women, and foreigners were also liable to serve as victims, slaves, usually war captives, were the main source. Commonly, their fate, especially at funerals, was to be buried alive. One report in 1797 has it that between 1400 and 1500 people were sacrificed at royal funerals in Ashanti.
- 2.14** Slavery and the slave trade, then, were alive and well in Africa long before Europeans arrived to develop the export market. The Portuguese were the first to seek slaves from West Africa in the 1440s to make up for a labor shortage in Portugal and to man sugar plantations on their Atlantic Island possessions, not least Madeira. Between 1525 and 1866, the Portuguese Empire is reckoned to have shipped over 5.8 million slaves out of Africa, amounting to 46.7% of the grand total of African slave exports of over 12.5 million. After the Portuguese came the English or from 1707, the British, with almost 3.26 million slaves exported or 26% of the total, mostly between 1660 and 1807.
- 2.15** The conditions under which slaves were transported across the Atlantic were infamously dreadful, with the human cargo packed like sardines below decks, initially shackled, starved of daily fresh air and sunlight for all but an hour or two, malnourished, dehydrated, and prey to disease for a voyage lasting up to 6 weeks. According to one estimate of the African slaves shipped by British traders in 1672-87, a full 23% were lost in transit. It seems that conditions must have improved later since, according to another estimate, over the much longer period of 1662-1807, only 13.2%

died before they reached the shores of the Americas. However, even if this does represent an "improvement" , it still amounts to the loss of about 450,000 souls.

- 2.16** Most of those who survived the sea journey were deposited in the Caribbean, especially Barbados and Jamaica. Some were taken beyond, to the coast of the American colonies, mostly south of New Jersey. There they were sold at auction as pieces of property or chattels, usually separable from their families. In the West Indies and Southern American colonies, they were put to work on plantations, probably producing sugar, though perhaps tobacco or rice. Organized into regimented gangs, they were subject to severe discipline which was not infrequently cruel.
- 2.17** In 1654, a French priest, Antoine Biet, reported how one master in Barbados whipped a slave, "until he was all covered in blood and then cut off one of his ears, had it roasted and forced him to eat it." And there was worse. Of course, the treatment of slaves was not always so grim. Sometimes masters regarded them with a certain benevolence as members of their extended household, taking a kindly interest in their lives. Sometimes slaves were manumitted, freed, usually by paying an agreed price, less often by getting baptized or being granted their freedom in their master's last will and testament. Notwithstanding that, the slave remained radically dependent on his master's will and therefore radically vulnerable.
- 2.18** Because slavery had not existed in England since the medieval period, the English common law was completely silent on the status and treatment of slaves. That meant that the colonies were left free to formulate their own slave codes, which typically gave owners almost complete control over the movements of their slaves, whose company they kept, and how they behaved. Unlike indentured servants, they effectively had no legal redress against maltreatment.
- 2.19** Further, the conditions of work were very harsh, especially on the sugar plantations. Slaves commonly toiled for their owners for up to 12 hours a day, 6 days a week, without pay. They were malnourished, laboring in a very debilitating climate and prey to a wide array of diseases. Not unsurprisingly, they suffered a high rate of mortality. As a result, before the ending of the slave trade, none of the sugar colonies in the West Indies managed to achieve a natural increase in the slave population. That is why they had to keep on bringing in fresh supplies.
- 2.20** Even so, Jamaica, which had imported 575, 000 Africans in the course of the 18th century, still only had just under 349, 000 left in 1807. Famously in his seminal *Capitalism and Slavery*, published in 1944, the Trinidadian historian, Eric Williams, argued that profits from the slave trade provided a major source of capital for financing Britain's world-leading industrial revolution and made an enormous contribution to Britain's industrial development. But his thesis is that the slave trade made an enormous contribution to Britain's industrial development. Now, this thesis was and remains controversial. There are different views on it. Williams himself was quite clear in not claiming that the slave trade was solely and entirely responsible for industrial

development. So the dispute concerns the effect of slave trade relative to other factors. So how much did the slave trade contribute to Britain's industrial development?

- 2.21 In the late 1960s, Roger Anstey minimized its effect by calculating that the profits from the slave trade fell far below Williams' estimate and could not have financed the Industrial Revolution to a significant extent. Anstey's general view later found confirmation in C. H. Feinstein, the noted economic historian, who estimated that profits from the slave trade probably contributed under 1% of total domestic investment toward the end of the 1700s.
- 2.22 In 2010, David Brion Davis, the distinguished historian of slavery and its abolition in the Western world, confidently pronounced the last rites on Williams' thesis, writing that it "has now been wholly discredited by other scholars. " But you will still find some scholars who think that Williams was right. They tend to be Marxist. As I explain in my book, not in these lectures, when Marxist theory is put up against the data of colonial economics, Marxist theory does not come off well. The theory doesn't fit the data.
- 2.23 Nevertheless, the slave economies of British colonies did serve to fuel the growth of external trade and thereby generate the accumulation of further capital. The growing demand for sugar on the part of British consumers stimulated increased production in the West Indies, which in turn stimulated the importation of clothing and equipment from Britain and slaves from Africa. Kenneth Morgan, another economic historian, endorses an argument that Caribbean-based demand might have been responsible, might have been, we can't be sure, might have been responsible for about 35% of the growth of total British exports between 1748-76, for about 12% of the growth in British industrial output in the 3rd quarter of the 1700s.
- 2.24 As the effects of colonial slavery upon Britain are controversial, so are its effects on Africa. They're likely to remain so since data on trends in output and population in pre-colonial Africa are so scarce. Some argue that the Atlantic slave trade made little difference to most of Africa, though it might have a greater impact on the population and wealth of societies along its Atlantic Coast. Others hold that it had devastating consequences, causing widespread depopulation and economic dislocation, undermining the socio-political fabric of African societies, and propagating forms of slavery and servitude hitherto unknown.
- 2.25 Although it's impossible to calculate the costs of the slave trade to Africa with any precision, it makes common sense, I think, to suppose that British and European demand for slaves stimulated African endeavor to supply and thereby increase in war and slave raiding in Western Central Africa. While the British investors and merchants bear responsibility for that, so do their African suppliers. Commercial and political elites in West Africa and Central Africa appear to have made large profits from helping to meet the American demand for slave labor.

- 2.26** The British were actively involved in the slave trade for about 150 years until 1807 and in employing slave labor for almost three decades beyond that, until 1834. For most of that period, few condemned the institution of slavery as such. Even the Maroons, runaway slaves who hid out in the forested interiors of Jamaica and elsewhere, kept slaves of their own. Nevertheless, from the middle of the 18th century onward, both the trade and the institution of slavery came under mounting public criticism.
- 2.27** One leading catalyst for the emergence of the movement to abolish the slave trade and slavery in the 18th century was Christian. There were also ideas emanating from the European Enlightenment as well, but one of the main sources of ideas that fueled the movement against slavery and the slave trade were Christian. Anti-slavery sentiment flourished widely among the English descendants or non-conformists, especially the Quakers, and the Methodist or evangelical wing of the Church of England.
- 2.28** John Wesley, Anglican priest and founder of Methodism, prefaced his 1774, *Thoughts Upon Slavery*, with the quotation of Genesis 4:10. "And the Lord said, 'What hast thou done? The voice of thy brother's blood crieth unto me from the ground.'" The context is Cain 's murder of his brother Abel, and the implication of the quotation is clear. African and Englishman, slave and master, are brothers, common children of the same God.
- 2.29** Anti-slavery sentiment acquired practical political focus in 1787 with the founding of the Society for the Abolition of the Slave Trade in London. Among its founding members was Thomas Clarkson, who promoted the sale of the autobiography of Olaudah Equiano, a former slave from West Africa, and who collaborated with William Wilberforce and other members of the Clapham Sect in mounting and sustaining a campaign both inside and outside Parliament. Extra-parliamentary agitation was considerable, and the campaign was a popular campaign. In 1791, about 30% of the adult male population of Britain signed anti-slavery petitions. Remember, this is long before democracy hit Britain, only shortly after it was being developed in the United States.
- 2.30** Events overseas also played an important part in shaping public opinion at home. The 1791 rebellion of slaves in Saint-Domingue, Haiti—which neither the French nor the British could suppress, and which culminated in the foundation of the Independent Black Republic of Haiti in 1804—began to give abolition the appearance of historical inevitability.
- 2.31** The efforts of the campaigners finally bore fruit in 1807 when Parliament legislated to abolish the slave trade. It took a further 26 years to achieve the empire-wide abolition of the institution of slavery itself, initially because the leading abolitionists were politically conservative and assumed cutting off fresh supplies of slaves would doom the slave-based economies to wither naturally, gradually, and with minimal social and economic disruption. Even most black abolitionists were gradualists until the 1820s.

- 2.32 So the issue was, do we abolish it suddenly or do we let it wither? And politically conservative people, both black and white, thought, "Better let it wither so we can adjust economically over time." But when the plantations proved more resilient than had been expected—they weren't withering—agitation to hasten abolition picked up steam. This agitation intensified when news arrived of the savage retribution meted out to black rebels and their white missionary supporters in the slave revolts in Demerara in 1823 and then Jamaica in 1831-2. The following year, Parliament passed the Slavery Abolition Act, which came into effect 12 months later. And so on the first of August, 1834, slaves throughout the British Empire were formerly emancipated.
- 2.33 Now, one controversial feature of the process of abolition was the agreement to compensate slave owners for the loss of their property from a fund of £20 million, which was set up by the government and paid for by metropolitan taxpayers. That concession is controversial today, and it was controversial then. The government was already committed to abolition, but it preferred to win the consent of West Indian planters rather than have to coerce them. The shadow of the French Revolution and its terror was long, and it made unthinkable the idea of the state riding roughshod over the right to property. I should also say the British learnt from the American War of Independence. It learnt that Britain couldn't simply impose its will on a colony. One reason why Britain was unwilling to force colonial assemblies in the West Indies to abolish slavery. One of the ironies of the lessons the British learnt from the American War—that the payment of compensation to the slave owners was the necessary political compromise to achieve abolition.
- 2.34 The Anti-Slavery Society, which had been founded by Wilberforce and Clarkson in 1823, wasn't happy with many aspects of the Slavery Abolition Bill, but it supported it rather than jeopardize the momentum toward emancipation. Yet Clarkson was quite unapologetic about the compensation, viewing it, "not as an indemnification, but as money well paid for procuring the cooperation of the West India planters and legislators, without which the abolition of slavery might have been materially obstructed and retarded, if not prevented." Besides, since the planters faced ruin without compensation, not to have granted it would have bankrupted the plantations and destroyed much of the prospect of paid employment for freed slaves. Whereas in Jamaica, Trinidad, and British Guiana, many emancipated slaves found unsettled land on which to subsist. In smaller colonies such as Antigua and Barbados, where free land was not readily available, employment on the plantations remained the only option. So if you allow the plantations to go bankrupt, there is no work for freed slaves.
- 2.35 In recent times, the greatest controversy attending the abolition of the slave trade and of slavery itself stems from another thesis proposed by Eric Williams, whom we met earlier. In *Capitalism and Slavery*, not only did Williams hold that profits from the trade had financed Britain's industrial revolution, he also argued that the trade and the

institution had been abolished because they were no longer profitable. So in other words, it wasn't humanitarian reasons that led to abolition, it was economic interest.

- 2.36** Now, this second thesis has been quite as contentious as the first. Against Williams, Robert Anstey demonstrated in 1975 that in terms of economic interest, 1806 -07 was the worst possible time for Britain to abolish its slave trade, embroiled as it was in a long war with Napoleon. 2 years later, Seymour Drescher published *Econocide—British Slavery in the Era of Abolition*, which presented a massive empirical evidence that abolition amounted to an act of suicide for a major part of Britain's economy. Drescher showed that the value of trade between the West Indies and Britain had increased sharply from the early 1780s to the end of the 18th century, and that the West Indies share of total British overseas trade did not enter long-term decline until well after the flow of fresh suppliers of slave labor had been cut off. Although Williams continues to have some supporters, it's fair to say the weight of judgment among contemporary historians falls heavily against him.
- 2.37** The strength of abolitionist feeling in Britain was so great that it did not relax after persuading Parliament to abolish the slave trade and slavery within the British Empire. It went on to persuade the imperial government to adopt a permanent policy of trying to suppress both the trade and the institution of slavery all over the world. One sign of this enduring commitment was the emergence in the Foreign Office of a separate Slave Trade Department from 1819, which was in fact the office's largest department in the 1820s and '30s, maintaining its independence until 1883, when it was incorporated into the Consular and African Department.
- 2.38** During the Congress of Vienna in 1814-15, Britain used its diplomatic clout to try to secure support for a general abolition treaty between all the major European powers, but in vain. Before and after the Congress, however, she did succeed in getting nearly all the states still involved in the Atlantic slave trade to agree in principle to end it, including Portugal, Spain, France, Brazil, and the United States. Still, none of those would consent to a reciprocal right to search suspect shipping which was required to give the principle practical bite. Nevertheless, the British government persisted to such an extent that, in 1842, the Foreign Secretary, Lord Aberdeen, saw fit to describe anti-slavery diplomacy, "as a new and vast branch of international relations."
- 2.39** In addition to the velvet glove, the British also deployed the hard fist. Up to 10 ships of the Royal Navy was stationed off the coast of West Africa to disrupt the export of slaves until 1833. Over the next 10 years, their number rose as high as 19, and from 1844 to '65, seldom fell below 20. For several consecutive years, stayed at over 30, and twice reached a peak of 36 ships. At its height, the West African station employed over 13% of the Royal Navy's total manpower.
- 2.40** From 1839, naval patrols extended south of the equator, and in 1845, the Slave Trade Act authorized the Royal Navy to treat Brazilian ships suspected of carrying slaves as pirates, to arrest those responsible and to have them tried in British admiralty courts.

In 1850, Royal Navy ships began trespassing into Brazilian territorial waters to accost slave ships, sometimes even entering its harbors, and on one occasion exchanging fire with a fort. In September of that year, Brazil yielded to the pressure, enacted legislation comprehensively outlawing the slave trade, and began to enforce it vigorously.

- 2.41** Shortly before his death, Lord Palmerston, twice Prime Minister, wrote that, "The achievement which I looked back on with the greatest and purest pleasure was forcing the Brazilians to give up their slave trade." Meanwhile, back in West Africa, the British implied a variety of means to achieve the same end. The thesis of Sir Thomas Fowell Buxton, that the key to ending the slave trade and slavery in Africa was to promote alternative legitimate commerce, had found wide acceptance. This led to the setting up of trading posts, and then when the merchants complained of the lack of security, a more assertive colonial presence on land.
- 2.42** The year after strong-arming Brazil and after trying in vain to persuade its ruler to terminate the commerce in slaves, the British attacked Lagos and destroyed its slaving facilities. In 1861, when an attempt was made to revive the trade, they annexed Lagos as a colony. I mentioned earlier that most empires grow up haphazardly for different reasons. There's an instance. First abolish the slave trade, then develops trading stations. Trading stations need more security, so you expand on land. That was the logic in that case. Not in every case, but that's one of the logics.
- 2.43** On the other side of the continent, the British brought persistent diplomatic pressure to bear upon the Sultan of Zanzibar, which was the main port for the Great Lakes slave trade, which also depended on the Royal Navy to protect its shipping from pirates in the Indian Ocean. Treaties were assigned banning trade in slaves to the Americas in 1822 and to the more important Persian Gulf in 1845. In 1873, the Sultan of Zanzibar gave way when Sir Bartel Frere, governor of Bombay and a resolute opponent of the East African slave trade, threatened a naval blockade unless the export of slaves from the African mainland ceased altogether, and the slave market was shut down once and for all.
- 2.44** Bit by bit, the Zanzibar trade in slaves was throttled. The institution of domestic slavery, however, was tolerated until Zanzibar became a British protectorate in 1890. Between then and 1909, a series of measures gradually emancipated slaves, first of all, granting them rights against maltreatment and of self-redemption, and then adding a right to obtain freedom on application to the courts. Here, too, slave owners were compensated for their loss, partly in recognition that domestic slavery was sanctioned by Islamic law, but also to minimize the economic disturbance and political opposition.
- 2.45** The task of estimating the cost of all the Empire 's various efforts to abolish the slave trade and slavery worldwide over the course of more than a century would at least present a major challenge, both in scale and complexity. No one, to my knowledge, has yet tried it. Some, however, have developed an estimate of the expense of transatlantic suppression. David Eltis reckoned that this cost British taxpayers a minimum of £250,

000 per annum equal to about £25 million today for half a century. Moreover, in absolute terms, the British spent almost as much attempting to suppress the trade in the 47 years, 1816-62, as they received in profits over the same length of time leading up to 1807.

- 2.46** The American scholars of international relations, Chaim Kaufmann and Robert Pape, took a broader view. In addition to the costs of naval suppression, they considered the loss of business caused by abolition to British manufacturers, shippers, merchants, and bankers who dealt with the West Indies. They also factored in the higher prices paid by British consumers for sugar, since duties were imposed to protect free-grown British sugar from competition by foreign producers who continued to benefit from unpaid slave labor.
- 2.47** Overall, they estimate the economic cost to British metropolitan society of the anti-slave trade effort at roughly 1.8% of national income over 60 years from 1808. Although the comparisons are not exact, they do illuminate. Today, the UK spends 0.7% of GDP on international aid, and we spend just over 2% on national defense. Remember, Kaufmann and Pape are dealing simply with transatlantic suppression, not suppression elsewhere. They conclude their study, Kaufmann and Pape, that is, by saying that Britain's effort to suppress the Atlantic slave trade alone in 1807-67 was, "the most expensive example of costly international moral action recorded in modern history."
- 2.48** Set in the context of the history of the world or even just of Europe, Britain's involvement in slavery was nothing out of the ordinary. Everyone was at it, including, as we have seen in the case of Maroons, self-emancipated slaves. It's also true that British slave owners were not universally sadistic and inhumane. But when all the qualifications have been added, it remains the case that the transatlantic transportation of slaves and the treatment of them in the sugar fields was usually brutal, often cruel, and invariably life-shortening. The injustice was grave, systemic, and massive.
- 2.49** The British could not undo that past, but they did the next best thing. They repented of it and liberated the still-living. With all due respect to Eric Williams, they didn't just repent when it was economically convenient to do so. They did so because many of them had come to believe that making another human being one's disposable property both corrupts the owner and violates the dignity of the owned. That is to say, because they had come to believe that slavery was morally repugnant.
- 2.50** They abolished the slave trade within the empire, in spite of the advantage they were thereby handing commercial rivals who would continue to benefit from employing cheap, wage-free labor in sugar production and in spite of the loss of business to English exporters to the West Indies. And they abolished slavery itself in spite of the higher price that British consumers would have to pay for freely produced sugar and in spite of the cost of the taxpayer of compensating the slave owners for the loss of their

property in the sum of £20 million, which was about 40% of the government's budget at that time.

- 2.51** For sure, enslaved Africans played important parts, too, through the example of the creation of the Black Republic of Haiti, through the eloquent witness of Equiano and others, and through the slave rebellions that exposed the savagery of their masters. But it remains a fact that no black person cast a vote in the British Parliament, either in 1807 or 1833.
- 2.52** The decision to compensate the slave owners in 1833 is commonly used by decolonizers to discredit the abolition movement today, as Eric Williams' thesis sought to discredit it in 1944. There is no denying that it was a political compromise. But the truth is that peaceful politics often requires compromise, and some compromises are morally justified, even obligatory. Besides, the planters claimed that they faced ruin without compensation, and given the novel additional cost of paying wages to previously slave labor, that claim is plausible. It is a fact that even with compensation, many planters sold up within 30 years of emancipation, which suggests that their business model was indeed precarious. From this, it is reasonable to infer that without compensation in 1833, at least some plantations would have gone bankrupt with the consequent loss of employment opportunities for those free slaves who, for one reason or another, couldn't find land of their own on which to subsist, especially on Antigua and Barbados. Many ex-slaves chose to stay working in plantations after the end of abolition because of the housing, medical care, and food provided.
- 2.53** Subsequent attempts by the British Empire to suppress slavery were often attended by political compromise. Because however powerful the empire was, its power was not infinite. It did not have the resources to send ships or troops to every part of the globe in order to impose its will on unwilling natives. Even when it did send troops, it sometimes came off worst. Notoriously, in 1842, a British army of 4,500 plus 12,000 camp followers was annihilated in its retreat from Afghanistan. In 1879, 1,300 British colonial troops were overwhelmed by Zulu warriors at Isandlwana in South Africa. And in 1883, an 8,000-strong Anglo-Egyptian army was massacred at El-Obeid in the Sudan by the forces of the Mahdi, the purported redeemer of Islam. In this last case, the suppression of the slave trade was among the grievances of the Mahdists.
- 2.54** Lacking the power always to impose, the Empire often had to act against slavery by increments, being careful not to excite too much opposition. Basil Cave, who was Consul General in Zanzibar, when domestic slavery was finally abolished in 1909, bore witness to this when he reflected with satisfaction on the local history of British efforts at abolition. And he wrote, "All the time, British influence was being steadily brought to bear upon the Sultan. Whenever an opportunity presented itself, when the Sultan appealed for political, financial, or personal assistance, when some benefit was offered or conferred, occasion was always taken to introduce some fresh anti-slavery measure and to move one more step forward toward final abolition. As a result," he wrote, "the

whole of the servile population of East Africa has been freed from bondage without a hand and almost without a voice being raised in protest."

- 2.55** Contemporary British agitators in the cause of decolonization, whether they belong to the Rhodes Must Fall movement or the Black Lives Matter movement, clamor that white Britons need to learn more about their ancestors' involvement in the slave trade and slavery. This is because, they claim, the anti-black racism allegedly endemic in British society today derives from the white supremacism used to justify the enslavement of blacks in the 17th and 18th centuries. White Britons in the 3rd decade of the 21st century, so it is claimed, view blacks now essentially as white slavers and planters did in the early 18th century. Racist colonialism is what connects them, and it needs to be exposed, acknowledged, and repudiated.
- 2.56** The major problem with this story, however, is that it requires amnesia about everything that's happened since 1787. It requires us to overlook how widely popular in Britain was the cause of abolition from the closing decades of the 18th century onward. For example, referring specifically to the project to settle freed slaves from the American colonies in Sierra Leone in 1787, the historian Stephen Braidwood concludes, "The great majority of newspaper items covering the expedition were sympathetic in tone. The fact of intermarriage and the good public response to the committee's appeal for money to help poor blacks also indicate that racial hostility may have been less common than has often been supposed."
- 2.57** Commenting on the following century, the American historian, John Stauffer, confirms this conclusion. "Almost every United States black who traveled in the British Isles," he writes, "acknowledged the comparative dearth of racism there. Frederick Douglass noted, after arriving in England in 1845, "I saw in every man a recognition of my manhood and an absence, a perfect absence, of everything like that disgusting hate with which we are pursued in the United States."
- 2.58** Between the slave trade and slavery of the 18th century and the present, lie 150 years of imperial penance in the form of costly abolitionist endeavor to liberate slaves around the globe. The vicious racism of slavers and planters was not essential to the British Empire, and whatever racism exists in Britain today is not its fruit. That 's the end of my lecture, but let me just say that the lecture was drawn very heavily from the 2nd Chapter of my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*. If you want to read the full account, I refer you to the book. Thank you very much.

Lecture 3: Empirical Racism

At a glance — Biggar addresses the charge that empire was driven by racism. He separates genuine instances of racial injustice from the blanket assertion that racism defined the imperial project, arguing the evidence is more mixed than the decolonizing narrative allows.

- 3.1** So welcome back to this series of lectures on deconstructing decolonization, and welcome to this lecture, whose title is On Racism. So far, in my last lecture, I argued that the British Empire cannot be equated with slavery since the Empire spent the second half of its life devoted to anti-slavery. It follows that whatever racism persists in Britain today can't claim direct dissent from the inhumane mentality of slave owners and slave masters in the 18th and early 19th centuries. However, that alone does not suffice to acquit the empire of the charge of predominant racism because other causes, other causes, might have generated it. So notwithstanding its anti-slavery efforts, can it be said that the British Empire was centrally, essentially, racist?
- 3.2** Well, as with slavery, so with racism. Before we consider its bearing on the British Empire, we first need to reflect on what we're talking about. What do we mean by racism? We need to reflect on this because the meaning of racism has so expanded in recent times that it obscures several morally significant distinctions. It's made to apply to some phenomena that don't deserve it. A large part of this lecture will be comprised of my making distinctions.
- 3.3** An uncontroversial formal definition of racism would be a pejorative or negative attitude of one member of a race for all members of another race. So understood, what is objectionable about racism is what is objectionable about any prejudice directed at other people, whether they're members of a race, of a nation, a social class, or a religion, namely that it prejudges the individual by regarding him or her simply as a member of a group, automatically attributing to the individual that group's supposed characteristics which are stereotyped negatively. So, "all British people are stupid—Nigel Biggar is British—Nigel Biggar is stupid." That's prejudice, prejudging.
- 3.4** So the sense of racism, as I understand it, are two. First of all, the racial group is viewed in relentlessly negative terms. And second, the individual is not permitted to appear as anything other than member of a group. So the group is simplified negatively, and the dignity of individuality is brushed aside. All you need to know about Biggar is he's British, therefore, he's stupid. What distinguishes racism from other kinds of prejudices such as social snobbery or national chauvinism or religious bigotry is that its object is not simply a class of people within a society or a body of citizens of a state or a religious community. Its object is a race.
- 3.5** Now, in this context, what's meant by a race is not easily defined. In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, for example, there was a lot of talk about the Anglo-Saxon race. That didn't refer primarily to skin color, it referred primarily to culture. It referred to

those who share an English cultural and political heritage. Often, in referring to the Anglo-Saxon race, Americans were included in that. More commonly nowadays, race is used, even more imprecisely, to lump together all people who have white or non-white skins, obliterating all manner of final distinction between different kinds of white and black. I think the safest definition of a race is still a vague one. It refers to an ethnic group marked by distinctive physical and cultural features.

- 3.6** Nowadays, the sin of racism has been loosened and broadened to mean any negative judgment made by one race upon the culture of another, but especially by a white culture upon a black culture. This assumes a basic cultural equality and a radical moral relativism and is designed to contradict Western assumptions of superiority. Since all cultures are equal in their different kinds of sophistication and their moral systems, so it is claimed, no member of one culture can stand in moral judgment upon any other.
- 3.7** Yet, when I, as a 21st-century Briton, look back at my medieval forebears, it seems obvious to me that my 21st-century British culture is superior to theirs in a wide array of respects—scientific knowledge, medical practice, economic productivity, social equality, political freedom, and public safety. The common colloquial tendency to use the word medieval as a synonym for barbaric suggests I'm not alone in that perception. When I look back at my medieval ancestors, I think in many respects, my culture is superior to theirs, not in all respects. But if it's okay to stand in judgment on a previous phase of one's own culture and to reckon it inferior in certain respects, why would it suddenly become impermissible to stand in judgment on an analogous phase in a foreign culture? It's not clear to me that it should become impermissible.
- 3.8** So when Cecil Rhodes landed in South Africa in 1870 and for the first time encountered Bantu Africans, it was manifestly obvious to him that British civilization at that time was superior in natural science, in technology, in finance, in communications, in commerce, in naval power, and in liberal political institutions. It's my view that common sense tells us that he wasn't wrong.
- 3.9** It seems to me there may be solid grounds for reckoning one's own culture superior to another in certain respects. That qualification is really important: In certain respects. As a rule, however, it is unwise to suppose that one's cultural superiority is absolute. It's unwise to suppose that one culture is superior to another in every in a single respect and for all time. No culture is perfect, and no culture is entirely lacking in merit. There were plenty of Britons whose imperial self-confidence did not prevent them making discriminate judgments and recognizing virtue and value when they came across it in America, in Asia, and Africa.
- 3.10** To take a famous example, David Livingstone assessed Africans in 1857, and he's talking about Africans in southeast, southern Africa. He said, "I have found it difficult to come to a conclusion on their (Africans') character. They sometimes perform actions remarkably good, and sometimes they're strangely the opposite. After long observation, I came to the conclusion that they are just a strange mixture of good and

evil, as men are everywhere else." Moreover, even imperfect relative cultural superiority is never forever. Whatever advantage was won yesterday by a culture can be lost tomorrow.

- 3.11** The making of adverse judgments about another people's culture needn't be racist if it is discriminate—superior or inferior in certain respects—not a blanket judgment, a discriminate one. Nor need it be racist if it attributes cultural inferiority to a lack of development rather than biological nature. This is another really important distinction. To attribute inferiority to biology is to regard a race of people as incapable of development, as naturally inferior, and as fit always to be ruled by others and never to participate in self-government.
- 3.12** As I observed in my previous lecture, the Christian view of all human beings, white and black, as fellow children of God, fueled criticism of the inhumane treatment of African slaves in the 18th century. It also propelled efforts to Christianize, civilize, and modernize native peoples in the first half of the 19th century. In the second half of that century, however, the disappointment of early hopes of rapid improvement under colonial tutelage did help to put the wind in the sails of the pessimistic natural biological explanation for the underdeveloped state of native peoples. You got different explanations as to why some native peoples had appeared to be inferior in certain cultural respects. For some, it was a lack of development, a lack of education. For some, it was natural, biological, fixed.
- 3.13** But even in the final years of the 19th century, the likes of Cecil Rhodes did not see Africans in terms of biological racism. He did not regard them as naturally, eternally inferior. In a parliamentary speech given in 1894, he made this clear when he declared, "Now, I say the natives are children. They are emerging from barbarism. They have human minds. We ought to do something for the minds and the brains that the Almighty has given them." Here's the crucial statement, "I do not believe that they are different from ourselves." Because he believed in the possibility of African cultural development, Rhodes never sought to overturn the liberal, color-blind franchise that had existed in Cape Colony since 1853. This is a point I'll return to.
- 3.14** Cape Colony, South Africa, granted black Africans the vote on the same terms as whites in 1853. When in 1899, the Cape government proposed legislation that would have disenfranchised most native people, Rhodes protested, arguing that he had always, and I quote, "Always differentiated between the raw barbarians and the civilized natives, and that the vote should be extended to Africans under the principle of equal rights to every civilized man south of the Zambezi." The previous year, when asked to clarify what he meant by civilized man, he had added, "A man, white or black, who has sufficient education to write his name, has some property, or works."
- 3.15** Rhodes' view echoed that of J. S. Mill, the great patriarch of Victorian liberalism, who during the American Civil War, proved himself one of the most uncompromising and outspoken critics of slavery in the American South. Nevertheless, in the opening

chapter of his classic 1859 treatise, *On Liberty*, Mill wrote, "Those who are still in a state to require being taken care of others must be protected against their own actions as well as against external injury. Despotism is a legitimate mode of government in dealing with barbarians, provided the end be their improvement and the means justified by actually effecting that end." Now, that might sound intolerably patronizing, but it did not condemn barbarians as naturally barbaric. The barbarian's human potential was no less than anyone else's. In that basic respect, the barbarian and the civilized person were equally human.

- 3.16** Still, even if Mill's and Rhodes' views were not biologically racist, they will probably strike the typical contemporary person as insufferably patronizing. But if that is a problem, it can't be considered a racist problem because, in Rhodes' case at least, he was indiscriminate in regarding other people as like children needing guidance. In 1899, for example, he referred to the dons of his alma mater, Oriel College, Oxford, as children in financial management when he stipulated that they shouldn't be allowed to manage his benefaction because he didn't think they were competent. Rhodes was patronizing, but he patronized whites as well as blacks.
- 3.17** What's more, it can't be patronizing to believe, surely, that foreign people sometimes need help, guidance, or protection. Sometimes they do, in fact, need help, and sometimes they themselves know it. In 1919, the League of Nations believed that certain peoples, formerly governed by the ousted Turks in the Middle East, needed the support of, and I quote, "an advanced nation to stand by themselves under the strenuous conditions of the modern world."
- 3.18** King Faisal of Iraq, a man quite secure in his own self-respect, agreed, which is why he rebuked Winston Churchill when Churchill threatened to withdraw British help in 1922. After the First World War, the British were given a mandate to set up a state in Iraq to support the development of a new nation-state of Iraq. The British in the early 1920s were getting fed up with this because it cost money and they wanted to withdraw. But the Arab King Faisal said, "Don't withdraw. We need your help. Not forever, but we need your help." So you can't be patronizing to suppose that a foreign people need help because sometimes they do, and sometimes they know it.
- 3.19** What then makes a belief that others need one's help patronizing? The Oxford English Dictionary tells us that, to patronize is, "To treat with an apparent kindness which betrays a feeling of superiority." But in obvious sense, anyone in a position to help is in fact superior, whether in knowing more or having more resources. And a precondition of offering help is that they are first aware of their own superiority. So it can't be the awareness of feeling of one's own superiority as such that makes the offer of help patronizing. What does make it so, I think, is the abuse of the factual relation of superior to inferior, so as to make the beneficiary feel generally incapable and worthless. In other words, if I need help, and if you're going to give it to me, a precondition is that you recognize you have something I don't. In that respect, you're

superior to me. But there are different ways of giving help. You can give me help in a way that respects me, or you can give it to me in a way that humiliates me. The latter is patronizing.

- 3.20** I think the difference is captured in the English language by the distinction between dominating and domineering, and between being a lord and lording it over somebody. A patronizing benefactor is one who talks a lot and listens little, who thinks he has things to teach but not to learn, who always gives, never receives. So did the imperial British patronize native people? Yes, they often did. Faisal and others were not infrequently irritated by the high-handed manner of British officials.
- 3.21** But the British did not always patronize those they were trying to help. Sometimes they paid them the respect of making a serious investment in getting to know them well, learning their languages and customs, spending time among them, and learning from them. For that reason, even if they did not always agree with him, Arabs in nascent Iraq in the 1920s respected, admired, and trusted the likes of Percy Cox, who was high commissioner and then ambassador to Iraq from 1920-23. According to the Iraqi politician and scholar Ali Allawi, Percy Cox was, "A patient, determined, and insightful man, and his knowledge of Arab affairs was probably greater than that of any other person. He also had the rare ability to see into the motives of people from a radically different culture. He was quite liked by ordinary Iraqis who saw him as kindly, wise, and tolerant, and many parents named their children, 'Caucus.'"
- 3.22** We're now moving from the Middle East to India. In India, relations between imperial Britons and native populations changed over time and became more aloof. Just note here, I'm making distinctions again—we've got racism, we've got patronizing behavior, now we have aloofness—these aren't quite the same things. Relations became more aloof over time. During the 18th century and well into the following one, it wasn't uncommon for the British to mix with native people socially, even to the point of taking Indian women as mistresses or wives, having children with them, and sometimes even bringing their Indian families back to live in Britain.
- 3.23** A list of the founder members of the quintessentially establishment Bengal Club, set up in Kolkata in 1827, shows no signs of racial exclusivity. However, with the rising influence of evangelical Christianity and modernizing utilitarianism in the early 19th century, and their lack of sympathy, respectively, for pagan culture and traditional ways, social mixing between Britons and natives declined, and the two peoples became generally more estranged. Up until 1833, Hindu and Muslim holy men had blessed the colors of Sepoy regiments, and the British took part in Hindu ceremonies and festivals. Thereafter, such practices were discouraged.
- 3.24** The very bloody Indian mutiny of 1857 had contradictory effects on racial relations. On the one hand, it made Queen Victoria, Empress of India from 1877, highly sensitive to the feelings of her Indian subjects. In 1888, she rebuked her Prime Minister, Lord Salisbury, when he referred to Dadabhai Naoroji—who would become Britain's first

Indian member of Parliament—when he referred to Naoroji as a black man. 10 years later, she urged her viceroy, Lord Curzon, to hear for himself what the feelings of the natives really are, and to be careful not to trample on them or to make them feel that they are a conquered people. On the other hand, the mutiny made the tiny minority of Britons in India acutely aware of their vulnerability, as the wife of an expatriate civil servant vividly testified in 1884 when she wrote that she always felt as if she were living on a volcano, "with the elements of an eruption seething below the surface."

3.25 After 1857, British troops in India carried weapons into church services. A minority that feels itself beleaguered naturally becomes defensive. If it's a ruling minority, one way of defending itself is to impress its own natural superiority upon the ruled majority. And part of making that impression involves keeping one's distance, avoiding the equality of intimacy. That said, aloofness needn't be entirely a means of generating power. It can also be the innocent result of a natural preference for mingling with one's own kind, where a body of shared assumptions and social codes oils the wheels of social intercourse. Racial distance increases, therefore, when the number of expatriates enables them to form a socially self-sufficient society. Because immigrants, wherever, arriving en masse naturally form ghettos. In a strange land, we naturally move toward people who are like us. It's just easier.

3.26 Ronald Storz observed that racial relations in Egypt during the British occupation of the late 19th century were better when the number of Britons was lower. He wrote, "Those of the 1880s and '90s had left a fine tradition of tactful dealing and happy relationships with Egyptians." By 1910, however, the number had risen to the point where the British were mixing increasingly less with Egyptians and more with each other. "Yet," wrote Storz, "It would be unfair to ascribe these neglects and abstentions entirely to condescension or indifference. Between persons of different race, climate, language, and religion, the conversational going is not always easy, largely because of a common ground."

3.27 Writing of British members of the Indian civil service, known as civilians, around the same time, David Gilmour makes a similarly benign judgment. "Civilians," that is to say, members of the Indian Civil Service, "may have been racially aloof and even dismissive, but they weren't racist in the sense that they considered racial differences to be permanent and innate. They believed that they belonged not to superior race, but to a more advanced civilization. Anglo-Indians may have stuck together in civil lines and had holidays together in the hill stations, but most of them were fond of the people they ruled." Besides, not all members of the Indian civil service were aloof and dismissive. Some were fascinated. Pushing against Edward Said's postcolonial caricature of Western attempts to understand Eastern cultures as exercises in imperial control that violate their subject —so Said's view is that the interest of British colonial officers in native cultures was entirely about controlling them. So it was an exercise in power.

- 3.28** But pushing against that, David Gilmour writes this. "No serious survey of the scholars of the Indian civil service could conclude that they were a body of men who employed their skills to define an Indian other and create a body of knowledge for the purpose of furthering colonial rule. Most were like the German Orientalists who had no colonialist agenda of their own, men motivated by pure curiosity and a desire to learn." Such people investigated in a mood of inquiry, not in the spirit of James Mill, trying to find faults that demanded correction. Some might even admire what they studied—the character of the Buddha, the vernacular literatures, the empires of Ashoka and Akbar, the architecture of Agra and Fatehpur Sikri.
- 3.29** What imperialist use could be made of John Faithfull Fleet's work on the inscriptions of the Gupta Kings, or Evelyn Berkeley Howell's translation of the Massoud Ballads, or Arthur Coke Burnell's catalogs of the Sanskrit manuscripts in the Palace of Tanjore. How, one wonders, are such works imbricated with political power, as Said would say? How do they fit in with Said's theory that all academic knowledge about India is somehow tinged and impressed with, violated by, the gross political fact of British domination? So Gilmour's point is that, in this case, the British Indian civil servants were motivated just by pure cultural curiosity, as we often are. Sometimes we just find foreign things fascinating. We want to understand them. It's not all about power.
- 3.30** Moreover, insofar as aloofness was a trait of the British, they didn't possess a monopoly of it. Conservative Hindus, in reaction against British attempts to abolish customs such as those of child marriage and female infanticide, became more emphatic in their Brahmanical insistence on purification, especially in the preparation and consumption of food. This made it difficult for the British to interact socially with them. I quote again from Gilmour, "The British women wondered how they were expected to form friendships when Indians wouldn't eat with them, wouldn't invite them to their houses, or allow them to meet or even to discuss their wives and daughters. And understandably, lesser officials didn't find it easy to be friendly with a man who would wash his hands and change his clothes after their greeting and then refuse to eat his food if he thought their shadows had fallen across it. If Indians resented British high-handedness, the British found it difficult to warm to Indians who treated them like untouchables."
- 3.31** While some forms of racial estrangement in India were understandable and innocent, even if tragically unfortunate, others had no redeeming or mitigating qualities. Edward Thompson, who worked as a teacher and translator in India from 1910-23, reported that in the 1860s, the commercial development of tea and coffee cultivation, the cotton and jute industries, and foreign trade brought to India a flood of English planters and businessmen who had been influenced by the wave of anti-Indian feeling after the Indian mutiny of 1857. These people, according to Thompson, were indiscriminately contemptuous of all things Indian and had a far stronger sense of racial superiority than their predecessors. They were also sufficient in number to develop a communal sense

and bring corporate pressure to bear upon the Indian government, most famously emasculating the Ilbert Bill's proposal in 1883 to extend the presidency of Indian magistrates over the trials of Europeans by allowing the accused to opt for trial by jury composed of half or a majority of Britons.

- 3.32** Even during the Second World War, casual racist contempt was alive and well. Looking back on his experience as a young officer in the Royal Indian Navy, the Indian B.C. Dutt recalled the attitude he and his Indian comrades met in their British counterparts, "If we came into contact, their attitude, their talk, their language, there was no question of hiding it. The greeting was, 'Hi, black bastard.' It was so made that in my regiment or group, which consisted of practically all the communities of India, including Anglo-Indians, who had been very pro-British, every single one of us, by the time we came back from the battlefield, were all anti-British."
- 3.33** Yet there was a significant difference in racial attitudes between Britain itself and its colonies. Indians were often struck by the contrast between the friendliness of the British at home and their aloofness in India. Renuka Ray, a young woman who was educated in England before proceeding to convent school in Kolkata in 1912, claimed that she, "never knew that there was such a thing as color prejudice until she returned to India."
- 3.34** Two decades earlier, Mohandas Gandhi, later Mahatma Gandhi, had had the same experience. During the 2 1/2 years he spent in London studying to qualify as a barrister, he had, he wrote, "experienced nothing but kindness from the English." However, after a brief sojourn back in India, he traveled to South Africa to take up a position there in 1893. A few days after landing in Durban, sitting in a first-class train compartment for which he'd bought a ticket, a white passenger objected to his presence as a colored person. When he refused to change compartments, a policeman was called who pushed him out onto the platform, followed by his luggage. The train went on its way without him.
- 3.35** Gandhi's experience of the contrast between Britain and South Africa was later echoed by Desmond Tutu's in the 1960s. According to his obituary in the Times newspaper in December 2021, "It was in Britain that he, Tutu, first began to realize the intrinsic evil of apartheid. British police officers were polite. White people did not take precedence in cues. He lost the sense of inferiority most black South Africans felt in the presence of whites."
- 3.36** Not all racial discrimination was clearly racist in motivation. This is a delicate point, but bear with me. In 1876, the ruler of Egypt, the Khedive, appealed to Britain and France for help in rescuing his government from insolvency. In response, London dispatched Evelyn Baring, later known as Lord Cromer. When Cromer first arrived in Egypt in 1877, his task was simply to put the country's finances on a sound footing. But the further he progressed in this task, the greater his conviction that the survival of his financial reforms required a wider transformation of government.

- 3.37** Alfred Milner, who served as Cromer's Undersecretary of Finance for 3 years, put it thus in his 1894 apologia, *England in Egypt*, and he wrote, "If we determine to base order not upon mere external force, but upon internal stability, then there was nothing for it but to reconstruct radically the whole administrative machine, to overhaul the government in all its branches, to stamp out the corruption which lay at the root of Egypt's misfortunes and to secure to all its citizens at least some elementary form of justice. The better way of restoring order implied long years of toilsome effort." But a radical overhaul couldn't just be organizational or technical. It also had to be cultural, even moral. Here Milner continues, "For what was the good of re-casting the system if it were left to be worked by
- 3.38** officials of the old type, animated by the old spirit? Our task, therefore, included something more than new principles and new methods. It ultimately involved new men. It involved the education of the people to know and therefore to expect, orderly and honest government. The education of a body of rulers capable of supplying it. The wit of man is not yet discovered the means to accelerate a moral revolution, and it is the moral revolution which is the essence of the business." So they were the British in late 19th-century Egypt, and they were there because the ruler of Egypt had asked for help because his government was bankrupt. They set about trying to reorganize the finances and realized that you can't reorganize the finances without reorganizing the government. Reorganizing government's more than just tinkering with procedures and structures. It also has to do with the culture of government. The British, rightly or wrongly, found the culture of the Egyptian ruling class as wanting.
- 3.39** The problem at root was not bureaucratic organization, but the moral quality of the culture of the ruling classes, as Cromer wrote to the Foreign Secretary, Lord Rosebury, in 1886. "I've never yet come across an Egyptian who was not inordinately afraid of taking responsibility, and who, particularly, if some slight unpopularity is to be incurred, was not only too anxious to shift the responsibility of coming to a decision onto the shoulders of someone else."
- 3.40** Consequently, the government of Egypt could not be entrusted entirely to Egyptians for some time being. As Cromer wrote in his annual report for 1906, "To suppose that whilst the occupation lasts, we can leave these extremely incompetent Egyptians to do what they liked about local affairs is little short of madness. It will not take years, but probably generations to change the moral character of the Egyptian people." Now, there you have a pejorative generalization about another people. I've said this is dangerous because it could be racist, either because it's an unfair description of the group or because it blinds one to individual exceptions to the general rule.
- 3.41** Now, whether or not Cromer and Milner's characterization of Egypt's ruling class at the turn of the 20th century was in fact unfair and racist is an empirical question. I think it's possible that it was generally accurate because human groups do develop cultures with characteristic strengths and weaknesses. Take a trivial example. Back in Oxford, I

supervise graduate students. I supervise graduate students who are often not British. Many of my students are American. In the last 15 years, I've noticed that American students, at least the ones I've had, take responsibility, take initiative, and are enterprising. British ones tend not to be. Now, I might be wrong about that, but that's my experience. It is possible for groups to have different cultures and different strengths and weaknesses. It really is. It's not racist to admit that. I'm a Brit, so I'm saying that it seems to me that my British students are lacking something. Not everything, but they're lacking something.

- 3.42** Back to King Faisal of Iraq—he wasn't king of Iraq until later, but shortly before he became King of Iraq—he also thought that the culture of the British aristocracy was significantly different and better than the culture of the Arab aristocracy. In February 1921, he went to spend a weekend at Chatsworth House, which is the grand country house of the Duke of Devonshire. There he met a young aristocrat, probably the Duke's son. Faisal was amazed to learn that this young man, the only son of the Governor General of Canada, had fought at Gallipoli and in Palestine during the 1st World War, and that a huge number of his relatives had been killed in that war. Faisal commented, "Would any of our rich Arab people do something like that? When one sees such things, one feels small indeed. That is how real nations live and are governed. If such a fortune were held by any one of our wealthy people, he would move heaven and earth to make sure that none of his family was conscripted."
- 3.43** Faisal's Arabs, of course, were not the same as Cromer or Milner's Egyptians, but there is Egyptian testimony that tends to confirm the judgment made by the two Englishmen. The US-based historian, Afaf Lutfi al-Sayyid Marsot, the niece of Ahmad Lutfi el-Sayed, the moderate nationalist founder of Egypt's first political party, agreed that, "Long years of Turkish misrule had not encouraged a spirit of initiative." She also thought that Cromer was entirely correct in his view of the Khedive and his clique who were indeed thoroughly incompetent.
- 3.44** Reporting that Cromer considered the emergent political leaders of native peasant origin, "for the most part exceedingly ignorant and devoted exclusively to the furtherance of their own personal interest," she agreed that some were undoubtedly as he described them. Although there were 2 notable exceptions, Saad Zaghloul, who later became Prime Minister, and Sheikh Muhammad Abduh, Egypt's greatest religious reformer. But Sayyid Marsot's qualification is one that Cromer himself would readily have accepted because he admired Zaghloul and had him appointed Minister of Education.
- 3.45** He also had a very high regard for "my friend Abduh," describing him as a man of broad, enlightened views. Cromer wrote further, "Abduh admitted the abuses which have sprung up under Oriental governments. He recognized the necessity of European assistance in the work of reform. He was a somewhat dreamy and unpractical man, but nevertheless a genuine Egyptian patriot. In my annual reports, I frequently spoke of

him in high terms, and no one regretted his premature death more sincerely than myself."

- 3.46** It seems to me that the Cromer's pejorative characterization of the Egyptian capacity for good government and political leadership was not indiscriminate, and it didn't prevent him from recognizing exceptions to the rule. If Cromer and Milner thought it wise to exclude native people from the highest controlling echelons of government, it was only provisionally until such time as they'd become trained in the necessary habits and virtues. Milner wrote, "As native governing capacity develops, as natives come forward who are fit for responsible posts now held by Englishmen, those posts should be resigned to them." In other words, when the Egyptians have been trained up, the English should go. Well, I give that to you as an example of how, in that case, it seems to me, a provisional decision to exclude Egyptians from the higher level government until the institutional culture has changed wasn't obviously racist.
- 3.47** One of the many evil supposed issues from the imperial presumption of one's own superiority is the license to interfere in the affair of inferior others for the sake of what you, but not they, consider to be improvement. Today's decolonizing critics portray this as essentially arrogant, disruptive, and destructive. Yet they can't argue that we don't have moral duties to foreign peoples, since decolonizers and others clearly and rightly think that Western powers have a duty to stop oppressing the former colonized. But if we have a duty to stop oppressing them ourselves, might we not also have a duty sometimes to try to stop them oppressing each other? And human rights activists must think so because they protest vigorously, both against foreign states when they violate the right of their own citizens be free from arbitrary violence and against foreign societies when they tolerate the abuse of women and domestic slavery. Such activists commonly call upon their own governments to intervene in some fashion.
- 3.48** In fact, the British imperial government was often reluctant to intervene because of the financial cost and the risk of provoking a violent reaction. In its early days, the East India Company, which which governed India until 1857, barred the entry of Christian missionaries because it saw them as cultural irritants and so threats to the peace. They didn't want missionaries interfering with Indian culture because that would annoy the Indians and the governing authorities had to deal with the trouble. Company officers were indeed horrified by native practices they sometimes encountered, but they often preferred to tackle them patiently and gradually. So, for example, Captain John Campbell, posted to the remote uplands of Southern Orissa in the late 1830s, found that female infanticide and child sacrifice were practiced among the semi-nomadic Khonds. He reasoned, however, that, "The superstition of ages cannot be eradicated in a day. Any increase in coercion would arouse the jealousy of the whole race." Consequently, he proceeded with great forbearance and persistent persuasion, and by the late 1840s, his patient methods had borne fruit. Female infanticides had vanished,

and incidents of child sacrifice were declining rapidly. A man of outstanding perseverance and humanity, Campbell ended into Khond folk memory as a savior.

3.49 When it came to the practice of Sati, whereby widows immolated themselves—burnt themselves alive—on the funeral pyres of their deceased husbands, thus saving relatives from having to bear the expense of taking them in, Sir John Malcolm opposed the proposal that the Kolkata government should abolish it, summarily. Instead, Malcolm allied himself with a Hindu holy man, Sahajanand Swami, and resolved upon a campaign to abolish Sati by gradual moral persuasion. Meanwhile, however, supported by Hindu reformers such as Raja Ram Mohan Roy, who assured him that the practice had no basis in the Hindu sacred scriptures, the Governor General, Lord William Bentinck, had decided to abolish it. This he did in Bengal in 1829, extending the law to Madras and Bombay in 1830. As it happened, the social and political disturbances that Malcolm and others feared were minimal. Note there the irony that in the face of this practice of the self-immolation of widows on their husbands' funeral pyres, the Briton, John Malcolm, wants to go quietly and gradually, doesn't want to create a disturbance, whereas the Indian social reformer wants it abolished.

3.50 To sum up, sometimes the sense that imperial Britons had of their own superiority was justified. Sometimes it consisted of the conviction that native people needed help that they could give, and sometimes that conviction was correct. Sometimes the natives agreed with it, and it did not patronize. Sometimes the sense of imperial superiority was confident enough not to vie with giving credit where credit was due and with recognizing native wisdom, beauty, and virtue when it presented itself. At other times, however, imperial superiority did take the racist form of unfair disparaging prejudice against native peoples, which too often manifested itself in humiliating contempt, physical brutality, gratuitous social exclusion, and racial segregation. This occurred much less at the imperial center in London than at the colonial periphery, and less among governors, civil servants, and missionaries than among soldiers, merchants, settlers, and planters.

3.51 Moreover, unjust prejudice against members of social and racial groups was hardly peculiar to the British. Indians were perfectly familiar with caste and religious prejudice and were wont to take disparaging view of Africans. Africans themselves were quite capable of racist contempt among themselves. For example, in the 1940s, there was an Irish man, Gerald Hanley, who became a novelist after the war, who was in the British Army, and he was in Somaliland, and he commanded units that comprised both Somalis and Bantu Africans. And he wrote this, "I had once tried hard to get the Somalis to give up their contempt for Bantu people. 'We cannot obey slaves,' Somalis told me. 'It's impossible for us to live under slave people even when they are in British uniform and have arms,' they said. I could not change the memory the Somalis had of a time when these Bantu people were slave material for the Muslim world to the north." My point is

simply that racial prejudice is not peculiarly British nor European nor Western. It's a widespread human phenomenon.

3.52 Further, racial segregation in the British Empire was sometimes as much the tragic result of native attitudes as the British ones. Even when Britons were its main cause, it was often motivated more by the natural desire to move easily among one's own people than by positive disdain for aliens. Once segregation set in, however, racial alienation and disdain could easily follow, and it did.

3.53 Yet, as we saw in the case of Egypt under Lord Cromer, professional exclusion from the higher ranks of administration wasn't always motivated by racism, but by the temporary need to wait for cultural change to embed itself in the character and habits of native civil servants, a need that native people sometimes themselves acknowledged. Of course, the longer the provisional exclusion was stretched out, the more frustration and resentment built up. But if some native resented the cultural changes thrust upon them by colonial power as disruption, others welcomed them as liberation. On the eve of granting independence to the African colonies in the 1950s and 60s, the British often found themselves criticized by both sides, by conservative Africans for interfering too much, by progressive Africans for interfering too little.

3.54 In a nutshell, the British Empire did contain some ugly racial prejudice, but it didn't contain only that. It also contained respect, admiration, and genuine well-informed costly benevolence. Indeed, from the opening of the 1800s until its end, the Empire's policies towards slaves and native peoples were basically driven by the conviction of the basic human equality of the members of all races. So while the British Empire did contain racism, it cannot fairly be said that the Empire was centrally, essentially racist.

3.55 This lecture has been largely an abbreviation of a larger treatment in Chapter 3 of my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*. If you want the fuller account, I commend the book to you. Thank you very much.

Lecture 4: Cultural Adaptation

At a glance — This lecture considers cultural adaptation and exchange under empire, questioning the view that all colonial cultural contact was simply domination, and looking at how ideas, institutions, and practices moved in more than one direction.

- 4.1 Welcome back to this series of lectures, Deconstructing Decolonization, and welcome to this fourth lecture, which has the title On Cultural Assimilation and Genocide.
- 4.2 So far in this series of lectures, I've argued 3 things. First, that the decolonizing claim that contemporary Britain is systemically racist lacks empirical substance. Second, that slavery cannot have been the essence of British imperial dominance, since that dominance was used throughout the second half of the empire to suppress slavery all over the world. And third, that while the empire did contain ugly racial prejudice, from the opening of the 1800s until its end, imperial policy towards slaves and native peoples was driven by the conviction of the basic human equality of the members of all races, notwithstanding unequal levels of cultural development or evolution. Therefore, it cannot fairly be said that the British Empire was essentially racist.
- 4.3 The cultural revolutionary decolonizing story contains one further historical claim, together with a moral one, namely, that the British Empire involved the wholesale disparagement of the cultures of non-white peoples and the unwanted imposition of modern British culture upon them, and that this amounted to a form of genocide. Those two claims will make up the focus of this lecture.
- 4.4 When the people of one culture meets another and dominates it in number and in power, only three outcomes are possible. Either the dominant people annihilates the dominated one, or the latter adapts and assimilates, or the two people separate—annihilation, assimilation, or apartheid. As in the case of the Beothuk people who Newfoundland, British colonial settlement did sometimes cause the annihilation of a native people, not deliberately, mainly through disease. Whether such a phenomenon really was the result of a deliberate contention and ought to be called genocide, as many are now wont to do, is a question I'll consider later in this lecture.
- 4.5 The third option, separation, of which African apartheid, or separateness, in post -1945 South Africa, was a version—the third option, separation, was not British imperial policy. Whether in Canada, Australia, New Zealand, or South Africa, British imperial policy was assimilation. Even where provisional separation or segregation was countenanced. The view that native peoples were essentially equal to Britons, possessed of the potential to become equally civilized, predominated in the imperial metropolis, even when some settlers on the colonial periphery doubted it.
- 4.6 Policies of assimilation usually started with such things as the creation of land reserves, the provision of native schools, the conversion of collective ownership into private property, the introduction of wage labor, and the promotion of agriculture. The

consignment of native people to reserves did involve segregation, but it was viewed only as an interim measure. Sir John A. Macdonald, Prime Minister of Canada, said in May 1880 in the House of Commons in Canada, "We must remember that they, the natives, are the original owners of the soil of which they have been dispossessed by the covetousness or ambition of our ancestors. All we can hope for is to wean the natives by slow degrees from their nomadic habits, which have become almost an instinct, and by slow degrees absorb them or settle them on the land. Meantime, they must be fairly protected." Segregation, therefore, was seen as a necessary step toward gradual assimilation.

- 4.7 According to the leading Canadian political scientist, recently deceased Alan Cairns, "The reserve system was thought of as a protected training school in which Indians, sheltered from harsh contact, could be readied for membership in the larger society." As a result, many native people did adapt. Supported by Upper Canada's policy of providing reserve natives with land, seed, agricultural implements, and religious improvement, education, and instruction in husbandry, the Algonquians rapidly adopted farming while seeking to maintain their cultures and societies. By the 1890s, agriculture on the reserves in the southern part of Eastern Canada involved the systematic use of animals and farm machinery and production on a commercial scale. Some native people became fully integrated into the modern wage-earning economy, and a small but important number acquired a formal education and entered professional careers.
- 4.8 Adaptation on the western prairies was more difficult because of the sudden collapse of the bison and the lack of an agricultural tradition. Nonetheless, the chiefs of the native peoples of the Western Plains understood the necessity of change, and so they viewed the so-called Numbered Treaties of the 1870s first and foremost as a bridge to a future without bison, deliberately extracting from the Confederal government of Canada pledges of assistance in converting to agriculture. As a consequence, by the 1920s, agriculture was quite well established on many prairie reserves. When the Hobbema Cree settled on their reserves around 1880, they had virtually nothing, but by the late 1920s they had come close to self-sufficiency. That said, there had been moves to deviate from
- 4.9 this general pattern of assimilation, in the direction of permanent separation or segregation. For example, Sir Francis Bond Head, who was lieutenant governor of Upper Canada from 1836-38, regarded attempts to convert native people to farming as wasted effort and proposed the removal of the Anishinaabeg to Manitoulin Island, where they could continue their traditional way of life. "The greatest kindness which we can perform toward these intelligent, simple-minded people," he wrote, "is to remove and fortify them as much as possible from all communication with whites." However, Head's proposal was abandoned in the face of a storm of protest from native

leaders, missionaries, and the Aborigines' Protection Society in London, bolstered by native support for the Crown during the rebellions of 1837-8.

- 4.10** The ascendancy of a policy of assimilation was signaled by the title of a piece of legislation passed by the assembly of the Canadas in 1857, the Gradual Civilization Act. This was explicitly designed to bring about the ultimate integration of native peoples and to remove all legal distinctions between them and other Canadians. To begin with, however, natives would have a distinct legal status as wards of the government who were denied the vote. But any native adult male, judged by a special board of examiners to be educated, free of debt, and of good moral character, would be free to apply for full legal rights and so become enfranchised. Just under 3 decades later, the 1885 Electoral Franchise Act gave the vote to all adult male Indians in Eastern Canada who met the necessary property requirements.
- 4.11** This was welcomed by natives such as Chief Charles Big Canoe and Band Councillor James Ashquash, who wrote to Prime Minister Macdonald to thank him for his "earnest efforts to promote the welfare of the Indian people throughout the whole dominion. We appreciate your difficulties in dealing with our less civilized brother in the northwest who had not had the advantages we in Ontario have had. We thank you most cordially for the gift of franchise", or vote. In 1886, Macdonald wrote to Peter Jones, otherwise known as Kahkewaquonaby, a Mississauga chief and Methodist minister, writing, "I hope to see someday the Indian race represented by one of themselves on the floor of the House of Commons."
- 4.12** This political assimilation wasn't unique in the British Empire, and Canada was not the first part to enfranchise native peoples. As I mentioned in my last lecture in South Africa's Cape Colony, black Africans were given the vote on the same terms as whites in 1853. Before the creation of the Union of South Africa in 1910, this produced only a small black electorate of 8,000, but that is reckoned sufficient to have had a decisive influence in seven of the 37 constituencies in the general election of 1890. Meanwhile, in New Zealand, the vote was extended to all Maori adult males in 1867, 12 years ahead of being given to their European counterparts when the property qualification was abolished. Indeed, from 1887-1894, an Irish Maori MP, James Carroll, known to Maori as Timi Kara, twice served as acting prime minister.
- 4.13** Mistakes were made and there were failings, of course. In Canada, the Indian Acts of 1876, for example, sought to preserve the territorial integrity of the native reserves by making real and private property immune from seizure by off-reserve creditors. The problem was, inadvertently, that it made it impossible for natives to raise capital for investment since they couldn't offer their property as security against loans. In the West, the Home Farm Policy for developing agriculture on the reserves was ill conceived
- 4.14** and launched in 1879, was abandoned only a few years later. The administration of native affairs during the famine of the late 1870s and early 1880s was rife with

corruption, and the company, contracted to deliver rations to starving natives, abused its privileged position to deliver substandard food.

- 4.15** However, the instrument of assimilation that now attracts the fiercest opprobrium, fiercest criticism, was Canada's system of residential schools. The motivation for establishing these schools was basically humanitarian, namely, to enable pupils to adapt and survive in a world that was changing rapidly. This was a general need that many native people themselves acknowledged, as they found themselves unable to sustain their traditional hunting and gathering economy.
- 4.16** As Chief Powles Claus of the Bay of Quinte Mohawk said at the July 1846 conference in Orillia, in what's now southern Ontario, "We cannot be a people unless we conform ourselves to the ways of the white man." Consequently, native leaders actively lobbied missionaries to set up schools that would teach their children agricultural skills, English language, and Christian religion.
- 4.17** By the 1840s the Anglican and Methodist churches, having experimented with different kinds of schools, both independently reached the conclusion that boarding schools were likely to be the most effective. The rationale for this was that the induction of young native people into English- or French-speaking farming culture would be advanced by entirely abstracting them from their inherited environment. Thus, in 1835, the Methodist missionary Peter Jones, himself a mixed-blood Mississauga who believed fervently that European ways and Christianity were for the benefit of the Ojibwa, advocated the removal of Indian children from their homes to boarding schools. 9 years later, the report of the Governor General's Commission on the Affairs of Indians in Canada recommended a policy of promoting residential schools.
- 4.18** Participation in the schools was entirely voluntary until 1894 and voluntary as a rule until 1920, when the government acquired the authority to compel the attendance of any child. Between 1883 and 1996, when the last of the schools closed, about 150,000 children attended them, which amounted to only one-third of native school-age children. Unfortunately, the reality of the schools not infrequently fell short of their humanitarian ideal. Too often, the discouragement of speaking native languages was unnecessarily strict. Native culture was generally denigrated and indiscriminately suppressed. The proportion of Christianity was aggressive, the time devoted to manual labor was excessive, and the time reserved for classroom education was inadequate. The diet, clothing, provision of medical services were generally poor, although students were conscious that the conditions from which they had come to the school were often no better, and even worse. There was also corporal punishment, bullying, and sexual abuse, the last perpetrated sometimes by members of staff but more often by other pupils.
- 4.19** Quite how extensive these feelings were is difficult to determine. Certainly they weren't universal. In 1886, for example, Red Crow, a powerful chief in the Blood Nation of the Blackfoot Confederacy, together with several of his fellow chiefs, had been

greatly impressed by the attainment of Indian youths at the Anglican Mohawk Institute. Moreover, had there not been a significant record of success, numerous Indian groups would not have lobbied, as they did, for the establishment of residential schools well into the 20th century— for example, among the Methodist missions of Central Alberta and the Anglican Diocese of Keewatin.

- 4.20** As for firsthand testimony, it's equivocal. J.R. Miller, author of the standard history of the residential schools, has commented as follows: "While there are many former students who testify to the damage that the suppression of their language and other things did to them and to people they knew, there are also former students who firmly deny that their school experience scarred them or their fellow students. Too many ex-pupils have spoken positively of the experience as a whole, or of particular school workers who befriended them, or even of the balance of positive consequences that they struck after weighing both sides, to justify ignoring or downplaying such memories. Too many argue that the schools were important sources of knowledge and preparation for them to trivialize all positive recollections as the products of individual peculiarities." Consequently, Miller concludes, "The verdict on the full effect of residential schools on native identity must be given in muted and equivocal tones." Those, however, are not the tones in which the verdict is now almost universally given. Nowadays, the residential school system in Canada is commonly represented as the expression of a "conscious racist strategy to exterminate aboriginal peoples," and as a form of "cultural genocide."
- 4.21** To take one eminent example, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada opened the summary volume of its final report in 2015 thus: "For over a century, the central goals of Canada's aboriginal policy were to eliminate aboriginal governments, ignore aboriginal rights, terminate the treaties, and, through a process of assimilation, cause aboriginal peoples to cease to exist as distinct legal, social, cultural, religious, and racial entities in Canada." The establishment and operation of residential schools was a central element of this policy, which can best be described as cultural genocide.
- 4.22** The historical connotations of genocide encourage identification with the Nazi paradigm, and some have exploited this. So in their 1997 book, *The Circle Game*, Roland Chrisjohn and Sherri Young compared the residential school experience to the Holocaust, equating it with Hitler's attempts to create an Aryan master race. More recently, the attention drawn to unmarked graves and cemeteries associated with the residential schools has been broadcast by native representatives, the Canadian press, the New York Times, and Al Jazeera as the discovery of mass graves with all the connotations of mass murder, such as the Nazis perpetrated.
- 4.23** The assertion of judgments as extreme and misleading as this has been aided by the deliberate suppression of evidence to the contrary. Writing of the early 1990s, Miller observed, "that what is sometimes disturbing is that at least some former pupils with positive memories tried unsuccessfully to place their positive recollections before the

public via the press and electronic media, only to be rebuffed or ignored. For the most part, former students and former staff members who wish to provide a positive recollection or introduce some balance into the media depictions of residential school life have been relegated to the pages of denominational church publications."

- 4.24 Yet even Miller, who is scrupulous enough to introduce a measure of balance into his account and who rejects the description of genocide, tends to exaggerate the sins of the residential schools. This is mainly because of his undifferentiated understanding of racism, which he asserts was pervasive in Euro-Canadian society. A large part of what he means here is that European Canadians judged native ways by their own standards, and, finding them wanting, were confirmed in their own racial superiority. But surely it's true that every people judges a foreign people by its own standards, and surely sometimes a people recognizes foreigners as superior in certain respects, and it's quite correct to do so.
- 4.25 Many native people observing European culture recognized its superiority in terms of writing, technology, agriculture, and medicine. That is why they wanted schools where their children could learn from it, so that future generations might share in its benefits. And those natives who chose to convert to Christianity presumably found something attractive in its worldview that was lacking in their inherited religion. Since it really is possible for one culture to be superior to another in certain respects, it cannot be racist to recognize it. And since native people sometimes agreed with Europeans that the latter's culture was superior in certain respects, it can hardly have been racist for Europeans to suppose it.
- 4.26 What would have been racist is the European view that there was nothing at all redeeming in native culture and a consequently dismissive regard for it. And it seems that this was in fact the view of some missionaries who showed a patronizing lack of sympathy for the inherited culture of their native pupils and sometimes presented a sharp Manichaeian dichotomy between European Christian virtue and native pagan vice. It was this attempt at total cultural assimilation as distinct from partial adjustment or adaptation that Miller rightly objects to. Yet such an indiscriminate attitude wasn't universal, as he himself observes, "Clerics and bureaucrats frequently commented on the mental quickness or the natural intelligence of the Indian, and they often noted as well the admirable ethical qualities of aboriginal society in its undisturbed state." Edgar Dewdney, the deputy minister responsible for Indian policy at the time the industrial schools were developed in 1884, thought that, "Indians as a rule are as intelligent, as amenable to reason, as white men."
- 4.27 What would have been even more deeply racist is the view that native peoples were biologically inferior, forever destined by nature to occupy a lower level of existence. And Miller occasionally suggests that this was the prevalent view, as when he tells us that Christian thinking in Canada, the US, and Britain had become suffused with racist preconceptions, partially as a result of scientific racism, which he associates with social

Darwinism. But this is quite wrong, because the Christian humanitarianism that dominated so much colonial thinking in the wake of the abolition of slavery was based on the premise of the fundamental equality of all races under God, which implies that such racial inequality as exists is merely developmental, not essential. And this Christian view was not generally eclipsed by its social Darwinist rival in the English-speaking world.

4.28 As Colin Kidd writes, "Even at the high noon of 19th century racialism, theological imperatives drove the conventional mainstream of science and scholarship to search for mankind's underlying unities. The emphasis of racial investigation was not upon divisions between races but on race as an accidental epiphenomenal mask concealing the unitary, adamic origins of a single extended human family. Quietly, subtly, and indirectly, theological needs drew white Europeans into a benign state of denial, a refusal to accept that human racial differences were anything other than skin deep." The refusal to accept that human racial differences were anything other than skin deep. The color doesn't matter, basically. Theological factors, more than any other, dictated that the proof of sameness would be the dominant feature of Western racial science.

4.29 Nor was the Christian view displaced in Canada. From his analysis of debates in the Canadian House of Commons from 1880-1925, Glenn Williams concludes that, "Although it was growing in influence in the late 19th century, biological determinism never had the field entirely to itself. It was scarcely possible to stand in the House of Commons to make a speech denigrating a race without someone rising in principle objection to remarks that they considered un-British, un-Christian, illiberal, or just plain prejudiced. And Miller himself obliquely admits this when he writes that, "Had scientific racism dominated Christian Canada, there would have been no experiment in Indian schooling at all, let alone the ambitious industrial schools after 1883, for what," he asks, "would have been the point?" In other words, you don't develop schools or provide schools to enable native pupils to develop if you don't think they're capable of development. So the schools were premised on the idea that native peoples were not by nature inferior.

4.30 The root of many of the failings of the residential schools in Canada lay in the inadequacy of their funding, which was exacerbated by a change of confederal policy in 1892. Resolved to reduce the rising demand upon the public purse, which was fuelled by the expansion on the number of schools in 1883, the government terminated the policy of full funding and introduced a new system of per-head grants, which remained in place until the 1950s. This tighter financial regimen had the unhappy effect of making school administrators desperate to recruit and retain pupils, even sick and contagious ones, and of worsening their diet and increasing their manual labor. It also inclined schools to employ under-trained teachers. In 1907, a report by the chief medical officer of the Department of Indian Affairs, Dr. P.H. Bryce, revealed appalling health and mortality statistics. As a consequence, 3 years later, an agreement was reached

between the government and the missionary societies, which increased public funding, improved living conditions, enhanced medical facilities, and tightened government inspection and enforcement.

- 4.31 Miller is generally scathing about the parsimonious bureaucrats in Ottawa whose agenda was set by the bottom line, and he hints that racist bias lay at the bottom of their parsimony. "The importance of educating and training Indians as a means of civilizing them was always lower in government priorities than other proposed expenditures. The malignant neglect of a federal government that did not care enough about the welfare of children who were its legal wards."
- 4.32 On which I comment as follows: No doubt Ottawa could have cared more and spent more, and no doubt the welfare of native children was not at the top of its agenda. But the fact is that governments, then as now, were subject to a multiplicity of claims upon public funding whose total demand always outstripped supply. Governments had to prioritize both according to their consciences and according to political constraints. It is probably true that the confederal government of Canada could have spent more on residential schools, but the question of whether it should have done, given all its other responsibilities, is a moot point, and an answer to that question would require a careful argument, which Miller does not give us. Moreover, one obstacle in the way of his hypothesis about racist parsimony is that, at least according to some experts, Ottawa's funding of relief for Western natives during the famine of 1882 was in fact, "a substantial segment of overall government expenditure."
- 4.33 The wholesale damnation of the residential school system in Canada is overwrought and unfair, I think. Notwithstanding their failings and the suffering caused by them, the schools were founded on a belief in essential racial equality and consequent faith in the capacity of native people to learn, adapt, and develop. Moreover, as the Canadian political scientist Frances Widdowson and her partner Albert Howard have written, "What would have been the result if aboriginal people had not been taught to read and write, to adopt a wider human consciousness, or to develop some degree of contemporary knowledge and disciplines? Hunting and gathering economies are unviable in an era of industrialization, and were it not for the educational and socialization efforts provided by the residential schools, aboriginal people would be even more marginalized and dysfunctional than they are today."
- 4.34 It's my view that no culture has a moral right to be immune to change or even to survive. Feudal culture in Europe had no just claim to be preserved against agricultural improvement, industrialization, and urbanization in themselves as distinct from the sometimes brutal manner of their development. Not much more now remains of the culture of 18th or 19th century rural England than the walls of cottages, Morris dancing, and the folk songs that Percy Grainger and others assiduously recorded just before the singers died out in the early 1900s. And as for the paleolithic and neolithic peoples of the British Isles, who were the cultural equivalents of some of the native

peoples that Britons first encountered in North America, Africa, and Australia, not much more remains of them than stone arrowheads and burial mounds. We may think that sad, but it wasn't unjust.

- 4.35 As I mentioned, the 2015 final report of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada chose to describe the residential schools as the means of perpetrating cultural genocide. The British historian Tom Lawson writes in the same terms of the similar Australian government policy between 1905 and the early 1970s of forcibly removing Aboriginal children from their families into government- or church-run institutions. The policy's rationale was that, while the pure-blooded aboriginal population was in rapid and terminal decline, mixed-race children could be saved by being assimilated to the mainstream European society.
- 4.36 Estimates of the number of children involved range from 20,000 to more than 100,000. Of this, Lawson writes, "The logic of the British presence in Tasmania and indeed in continental Australia, looked forward to, and indeed demanded a future free of the original owners of the soil. It is only the idea of genocide, incorporating both cultural and physical destruction, that can fully capture the totality of the project to undermine and destroy indigenous populations and culture."
- 4.37 I regard the use of the word genocide here as grotesquely misleading. I agree with the Australian historian, Henry Reynolds, in holding that the issue of intention is both morally and legally critical to the concept of genocide. Reynolds observes that Raphael Lemkin— who coined the term genocide and pioneered the drafting of the 1948 Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide— distinguished between, on the one hand, cultural genocide, aiming at, that is, intending, the annihilation of the cultural life of a group and using drastic methods to achieve it and, on the other hand, a policy aiming at or intending assimilation and using only moderate coercion.
- 4.38 Both the Canadian and Australian policies were of the second kind, not the first. In both cases, the residential schooling of native children was intended to assimilate them to European culture so that they could adapt, survive, and flourish in a rapidly modernizing world. Its intention was to save, not to destroy, even if sufficient adaptation to the New World would inevitably involve some loss of the old. Besides, Lemkin's proposal to include cultural genocide in the 1948 genocide convention was eventually rejected, and the concept remains outside international law to this day.
- 4.39 And it seems to me right that it should remain there. And that's because the paradigm of genocide, both in 1948 and today, is Auschwitz. My view is when we in the early 21st century think of genocide, Auschwitz is the first thing comes into our mind. That's the paradigm, Auschwitz and the Nazi policy of the final solution of the so-called Jewish problem. Then the clue is in the literal meaning of the word genocide. Cide—killing, geno—people. The killing of a people. And I cannot agree with those who argue that there is no qualitative difference between mass murder and cultural genocide because

the latter destroys the indigenous systems of meaning and ultimately the survivors' will to live, resulting in widespread death.

- 4.40 Whatever distress it causes, cultural assimilation does not aim to kill and does not necessarily, usually or directly, have the effect of killing. It aims to save by means of adaptation. Whatever their failings, and there certainly were some, there is a vast moral difference between the Canadian and Australian policies of residential schooling for native children on the one hand, and the Nazi policy of the extermination of the Jews on the other. Those who choose to describe the former as cases of genocide deliberately blur an important moral and legal distinction.
- 4.41 In North America, Australasia, and Africa, the policies of the imperial government in London and consequently those of the colonial governments beneath it were based on the Christian Enlightenment conviction of the basic human equality of members of all races and driven by the humanitarian desire to enable less advantaged, less privileged peoples to survive, develop, and flourish.
- 4.42 In 1837, the parliamentary Select Committee on Aborigines declared in its report, "The British Empire has been signally blessed by providence and her eminence, her strength, her wealth, her prosperity, her intellectual, her moral and her religious advantages are so many reasons for peculiar obedience to the laws of God, who guide the destinies of nations. These were given for some higher purpose than commercial prosperity and military renown. He, who has made Great Britain what she is, will inquire at our hands how we have employed the influence He has lent to us in our dealings with the untutored and defenseless savage, whether it has been engaged in seizing their lands, warring upon their people, and transplanting unknown disease and deeper degradation through the remote regions of the earth, or whether we have, as far as we have been able, informed their ignorance and invited and afforded them the opportunity of becoming partakers of that civilization, that innocent commerce, that knowledge, and that faith with which it has pleased a gracious providence to bless our own country."
- 4.43 In addition to metropolitan humanitarians, colonial officials, as well as missionaries and many soldiers, traders, and settlers, were also distressed at the evidently destructive effect of their presence on native peoples, and they sought to ameliorate the consequences. Having decided that they couldn't stop the mass migration of European settlers or reverse the process of colonization, they sought to manage it humanely. If they adopted policies of racial segregation, it was almost invariably as a temporary measure to protect native people from harmful encounters with settlers and to enable them to begin to adapt to a new, modern way of life. They were separated only in order to be assimilated, and they were assimilated in order to be saved. Not infrequently, native people themselves
- 4.44 recognized the need to adapt, and they sought help in so doing. Regrettably, the education offered them was sometimes racist, denigrating native culture indiscriminately. Nevertheless, many natives did learn to survive and flourish in the

new modern colonial world. Certain historians have chosen to exploit the connotations of the word genocide so as to approximate colonial policies of assimilation to the Nazi Holocaust. Such language is misleading to the point of slander. In fact, the British Empire's policies of assimilation were intended to rescue native people from a past that was irrecoverable, so that they might flourish in a future that was unavoidable and that they might do so as equal citizens.

4.45 What I've just given you is an abbreviation of Chapter 5 of my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*. If you want the more comprehensive account, then I refer you to that. Thank you very much.

Lecture 5: Colonial Reparations

At a glance — Biggar takes up demands for colonial reparations, weighing the moral and practical arguments and the difficulties of assigning present-day liability for a complex and distant past.

- 5.1** Welcome back to this series of lectures on Deconstructing Decolonization. And welcome to this fifth lecture on Reparations and Restitution. So far in this course, my deconstruction of the cultural revolutionary story about decolonization has argued that contemporary Britain is not systemically racist, that slavery was not the epitome, the essence of the British Empire, the Empire was not essentially racist, and its consistent policy of cultural assimilation was intended to rescue, not destroy, native peoples, and therefore did not amount to genocide.
- 5.2** In this lecture, I'll address the question of whether the British today ought to pay reparations to the descendants of those who suffered the evils of British colonial rule. "To attempt to judge an empire," wrote the African colonial expert, Margery Perham, in 1961, "would be rather like approaching an elephant with a tape measure." Approaching an elephant with a tape measure. I think the problem is actually worse since empires such as the British one, were rather less coherent than an elephant and involved mixtures of good and evil that defy any straightforward weighing up together.
- 5.3** Let me begin by drawing up a tally, first of all, of the evils and then of the goods of British colonial rule. And by evils here, I mean not just culpable, blameable, wrongdoing, or injustice. I also mean unintended harms. On the debit side of the colonial ledger, we find brutal slavery, the epidemic spread of devastating disease, economic and social disruption, the unjust displacement of natives by settlers, failures of colonial government to prevent settler abuse and to prevent famine, elements of racial alienation and racist contempt, policies of needlessly wholesale cultural suppression, miscarriages of justice, instances of unjustifiable military aggression, and the indiscriminate and disproportionate use of force, and the failure to admit native talent to the higher echelons of colonial government on terms of equality quickly enough to forestall the buildup of Nationalist resentment. All those are evils. All of them are lamentable, and where culpable, they merit moral condemnation.
- 5.4** But there is a credit side to the colonial ledger as well, and there are plenty of native people who agree with that claim. In July 2005, the then Prime Minister of India, Manmohan Singh, was awarded an honorary degree by the University of Oxford. Upon receiving it, he said this: "India's experience with Britain has had its beneficial consequences, too. Our notions of the rule of law, of a constitutional government, of a free press, of a professional civil service, of modern universities and research laboratories, have all been fashioned in the crucible where an age-old civilization of India met the dominant empire of the day. These are all elements which we still value and cherish. Our judiciary, our legal system, our bureaucracy, and our police are all great institutions derived from British Indian administration, and they have served our

country exceedingly well. The idea of India as enshrined in our Constitution, with its emphasis on the principles of secularism, democracy, the rule of law, and above all, the equality of all human beings, irrespective of caste, community, language,

5.5 or ethnicity, has deep roots in India's ancient culture and civilization. However, it is undeniable that the founding fathers of our Republic were also greatly influenced by the ideas associated with the Age of Enlightenment in Europe. Our Constitution remains a testimony to the enduring interplay between what is essentially Indian and what is very British in our intellectual heritage."

5.6 More broadly than simply India, the credit column in the British imperial ledger contains the following items. If the empire initially presided over the slave trade and slavery, it renounced both in the name of basic human equality and then led endeavors to depress them worldwide for a century and a half. The empire also moderated the disruptive impact of Western modernity upon very unmodern societies, promoted a worldwide free market that gave native producers and entrepreneurs new economic opportunities, created regional peace by imposing an overarching imperial authority on multiple warring peoples, involved necessarily representatives of native peoples in the lower echelons of government, sought to relieve the plight of the rural poor and protect them against rapacious landlords, provided a civil service in a judiciary that was generally and extraordinarily incorrupt.

5.7 Developed public infrastructure, made foreign investment attractive by reducing the risks through establishing political stability and the rule of law, disseminated implemented modern agricultural methods and medicine, stood against German aggression, first militarist, then Nazi, and fought international law and order in 2 World Wars, helping to save both the Western and the non-Western world for liberal democracy, brought up 3 of the most prosperous and liberal states now on Earth—Canada, Australia, and New Zealand— gave birth to 2 more—the United States and Israel—evolved into a loose consensual multiracial international organization—the Commonwealth of Nations—which some states that never belonged to the Empire have opted to join, Mozambique in 1995 and Rwanda in 2009. Through the Wartime Anti-Fascist Alliance of 1939- 45, evolved into an important part of the postwar Western alliance against Soviet and Chinese communism, and still has a significant afterlife in the Western military alliance of NATO and the intelligence alliance of the so-called Five Eyes.

5.8 So the British Empire did good as well as evil. But did it do more good than evil, or more evil than good? Some of those who advocate reparations for colonial evils think that it did more evil than good, but they assume so without arguing their case. They don't argue their case, I guess, because they're aware that it cannot be easily argued, nor can the countercase. And that's because the goods and evils that the empire caused, intentionally or not, are of such different kinds that they can't be measured against one another. They are incommensurable.

- 5.9 How much chalk is worth so much cheese? How much racism is worth so much immunization against disease? How many unjustly killed people are worth the blessings of imperial-imposed peace? How much humanitarian anti-slavery would make up for the evils of slavery? To ask these questions, I think, is immediately to expose their absurdity. Such varied goods and evils can't be sensibly reduced to a common currency and then waived against each other, so that we can conclude that one set was more evil than another. Here, as often elsewhere, a utilitarian calculation cannot be conducted rationally.
- 5.10 Given that all kinds of human rule produce a mixture of good and evil. Even the Nazis built autobahns in Germany, and the Italian fascists made the trains run on time in Italy. Does it follow, therefore, that the moral difference between them is just a matter of degree, and we can't judge any of them to be, all things considered, wrong? No, I think it doesn't mean that. We can try to discern central values and principles that were consistently expressed and concordant goals that were earnestly pursued and realized, more or less. If these values, principles, and goals were gravely evil and immoral, we can then say that the rule was systemically unjust. If it wasn't systemically unjust, then we can say that it was systemically just, more or less.
- 5.11 Now, the most obvious candidate for a systemically unjust regime is, of course, that of the Nazis in Germany in the 1930s and '40s. Dominated by the mind of one man, Adolf Hitler, its view of the world was murderously racist and its aggressive expansionist nationalism unburdened by moral scruple. The death factories devoted to processing millions of Jews in the midst of the exigencies of war were not incidental to the regime. They expressed its resolute crazed heart.
- 5.12 It's no accident that the contemporary enemies of European and British colonialism, the critics of the West, try to assimilate or identify British colonialism with Nazism, because then we could all be sure that it was basically essentially evil, notwithstanding all the colonial building of bridges and railways. That's why we have claims of colonial genocide in 1820s Tasmania and 1890s Matabeleland, of racist callousness toward starving native Americans on the western plains of Canada in the 1880s, of crimes against humanity in Benin in 1897, and of concentration camps in South Africa in the 1900s and Kenya in the 1950s.
- 5.13 Moving in the same direction, if more subtly, are those historians who write of the racist or violent "logic" of British colonialism, implying that racism and racist violence consistently characterized its central driving force. However, as I've argued in part here in this course of lectures, and more fully in my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*, "It is entirely inappropriate to liken the British Empire to Nazism. Nor was it essentially racist or disproportionately violent, nor with due respect to Marxist critiques, was it essentially exploitative. From the early decades of the 19th century, its natural innocent concerns to promote trade and maintain strategic advantage were

increasingly supplemented and tempered by Christian humanitarianism, a commitment to public service, and a liberal vision of political life."

- 5.14** As Margery Perham wrote in 1961 with regard to Africa, "No record can ever be made of what was done, good, bad, and indifferent by Britain in her dozen or more African territories during the brief years of her tenure. The mosaic is too vast for its pattern to be seen at one time or from one viewpoint. We're always brought back to the question of standards by which to judge Britain's record. There can be no doubt that if the standard is to be the interests of the ruled, these have steadily counted for more as the period of empire continued. The existence of informed liberal opinion, the publicity of debate, the use of commissions of inquiry to probe every serious problem and grave event, all helped to this end. The African colonies, as the latest acquisitions, have greatly benefited from this progression in virtue." I should make clear that Perham was not talking about South Africa. She knew East Africa/West Africa. That was her expertise.
- 5.15** Also included in the liberal political vision was the good of self-government. This was something impressed on the empire by the American Revolutionary War, when the British realized that they could not keep tight control on colonies. It was a lesson well learned. 30 years after the American War of Independence, around 1820, in India, the 3 main British-dominated cities, Calcutta, Bombay, and Madras, are all governed by Scotsmen. All 3 Scottish governors in around 1820 can be found to say that British rule in India was not going to be permanent, and the aim of the British should be to enable native peoples to govern themselves decently and then to withdraw the British with good grace.
- 5.16** One of them, Sir John Malcolm—as it happens, he was born about 50 miles east of where I was born—Sir John Malcolm wrote in 1823, "Let us, therefore, calmly proceed on a course of gradual improvement, and when our rule ceases, for cease it must, though probably at a remote period, as a natural consequence of our success in the diffusion of knowledge, we shall, the British, as a nation, have the proud boast that we have preferred the civilization to the continued subjection of India." So the point is not to be permanently subjecting people. The point is to civilize and then go.
- 5.17** By 1930, Canada, South Africa, Australia, and New Zealand had become effectively self-governing. From 1919, the British were committed by the Government of India Act to widen Indian participation in government en route to the same political autonomy. This arrived in 1947 more abruptly and violently than was desirable, and it came to African colonies in the 1960s too quickly in the expert eyes of Perham. But she and others like her recognized that once nationalism had taken hold among native peoples, it couldn't long be resisted. "Once Africans had been fully stirred in racial self-consciousness and political awareness, prematurely, though this may be in their own interests, there was little more that foreign rulers could do for them."

- 5.18** And this was so mainly because colonial rule could not survive, as it could never have survived without the widespread cooperation of native peoples. I can't pull up the exact figures, but the numbers of Britons in India relative to the Indian population, even at the height in 1900 was tiny. I mean, a few hundred thousand Britons and several hundred million Indians. In Africa, sometimes the ratio of white Briton to black African was one to several hundred thousand. It was tiny. So the empire could not have survived without, for one reason or another, widespread native cooperation.
- 5.19** Recognizing the good that colonial government did sometimes bring, native peoples often found colonial government to be not only sufficiently legitimate, but the best available, even admirable and to be emulated. That's why in the 1950s and '60s, several million Chinese voted with their feet, fled the lawless Chinese mainland, and found refuge in the colony of Hong Kong. Hong Kong was not democratic, but it had the rule of law and it had a free press.
- 5.20** I remember speaking to a Hong Kong Chinese academic colleague in Oxford, and I asked him, "What do you think about the legacy of British colonial rule in Hong Kong?" He said, "Well, if China had been a liberal democracy, then Hong Kong undemocratic wouldn't have looked so good. But compared to what China was, colonial rule in Hong Kong looked rather good." He said, "My own grandmother was one of the refugees who fled China into Hong Kong in the 1950s-60s." He said, "She never learned to speak English, but she became a lifelong devotee of Princess Diana." Even now, I think it's undeniable that many Chinese in Hong Kong would have, given the choice, prefer life in a gradually democratizing, liberal, law-governed British colony to life under the arbitrary repressive thumb of the Chinese regime in Beijing.
- 5.21** When my book is published in a few weeks' time, there'll be one photograph in it at the front. It's of young Chinese student protesters in Hong Kong around 2019, waving a British flag. And there's a poster saying, "Hong Kong is British." In a certain sense. I mean, Britain had no longer controlled Hong Kong since 1997, but you get the point.
- 5.22** How in the light of all this, does the case in favor reparations for colonial evils, especially slavery, look? The principle that those who have benefited from an injustice should either repair the damage or compensate its victim is moral common sense. No one doubts, for example, that after the Second World War, Germany's government should have restored stolen property to its Jewish owners or compensated them for its loss. In those circumstances, the identities of the Jewish wronged and the Nazi wrongdoers, and the relationship between original victims and surviving family members, were all clear enough, and the harm done was definite and quantifiable. In these circumstances, reparation and compensation, I think, make good sense.
- 5.23** But the passage of time muddies the waters. As the moral philosopher, Onora O'Neill has written, "Claims to compensation have to show that continuing loss or harm resulted from past injury. This is all too often impossible where harms have been caused by ancient or distant wrongs. Is everybody who descends in part from those

who were once enslaved or colonized still being harmed by those now ancient and distant misdeeds? Can we offer a clear enough account of the causation of current harms to tell where compensation is owed? Can we show who ought to do the compensating?" The riotous jungle of history overgrows and obscures the causal pathways. In the case of British slavery in the West Indies and the American colonies, the victims themselves are, of course, all long dead, and short of God and afterlife and the final judgment, they lie forever beyond the reach of compensation.

- 5.24** As for their 21st-century descendants, their present condition, while perhaps owing something to the enslavement of their ancestors, also owes much to events and choices in the almost 200 years since emancipation. A lot has happened since. Can we be sure that they would have been better off had their ancestors remained in West Africa— some as slaves, some as sacrificial funeral fodder? Aren't there some descendants of slaves who now prosper rather more than some descendants of slave traders and owners? Indeed, the data suggests that quite a lot do. If you go online and refer to the relevant World Bank data, you will find that in 2020, life expectancy in post-slavery Barbados was 24 years higher than in post-slave trading Nigeria. Literacy in Barbados in 2014 was almost 40% higher than in Nigeria in 2018. Gross national income per capita in dollars international was 482% higher. In other words, measured in those terms, the descendants of African slaves in Barbados are much better off than the descendants of some of the people who traded slaves in West Africa.
- 5.25** Besides, if the intention is to right grave historic wrongs, why should slavery be the sole focus? The English plight of medieval serfs or early industrial workers dwelling in urban slums may have been better than that of slaves toiling the West Indies, but not much better. Moreover, why should British slavery be the focus? If the historic injustice of slavery is to be rectified, then it needs to be done fairly and across the board. If the British are to be presented with a bill for compensation, then so should the descendants of the inland African chiefs who sold other Africans to the slave traders, as well as the descendants of the Arab slave traders who sold the slaves to Europeans on the Coast. They all profited, too.
- 5.26** The British themselves should seek compensation from the descendants of the Barbary Corsairs in North Africa, who raided Cornwall in the 1600s and carted off whole villages into slavery on the Mediterranean Coast of North Africa. If the British, then the Americans also, because in its early years, the United States spent one-fifth of its entire national budget in tribute to the pirate states of Algiers and Tripoli to stop their raids on American ships and the enslavement of their American crews. One-fifth of the US budget was spent paying off raiders.
- 5.27** Yesterday's oppressors were often the day before's, yesterday's, victims. In a letter published in the London Times some years ago, a former British diplomat recounted a conversation he'd had shortly after Nigeria's independence, a conversation with one of the country's new rulers, and the ruler was pressing the case for Britain to compensate

Nigerians for decades of colonial oppression. After listening quietly and patiently, the diplomat's turn to reply came. "I entirely agree with you," he said, "and you shall have your compensation just as soon as we get ours from the Romans."

- 5.28** These issues hardly make an appearance in Hilary McD Beckles' case in his book, *Britain's Black Debt: Reparations for Caribbean Slavery and Native Genocide*, which presents itself on the back cover as "the first scholarly work that looks comprehensively at the reparations discussion in the Caribbean." Beckles' general view of British colonialism is expressed in his description of it as a "criminal enrichment project." And of its known features as its "terrorism of adults and ruthless exploitation of children, its maddening material poverty, and the racial brutality bred within the prison known as the Plantation." He claims that from the West Indies, the British exported the financially successful model of African enslavement to the rest of the colonized world. And he refers to Queen Elizabeth II's apology in 1995 for the "genocidal activities committed by the British in New Zealand."
- 5.29** Now, if you recall the items in the credit column of my colonial ledger that I listed earlier, in the light of that, I suggest that Beckles' summary of British colonialism seems wildly distorted. One particular symptom of Beckles' politically charged inaccuracy is that the royal apology he referred to in 1995 was for the punitive confiscation of Maori lands in 1865. However wrong that was, it doesn't amount to genocide.
- 5.30** Against the claim that Africans themselves were deeply implicated in the slave trade, Beckles argues that the Africans never reduced, "subordinate workers, political prisoners, and others subject to criminal punishment to the legal status of non-humans." He argues that this is the classic divide-and-rule defense in which victims are blamed for the victimization, that the majority of African leaders over time oppose the slave trade, and that African chiefs were forced to raid for slaves under pain of attack and enslavement themselves. That's what Beckles claims.
- 5.31** This is what I say in response. First, the West African custom of burying servants alive with their deceased master does rather imply a view of them as violently disposable property. I also observe that to blame African slave traders is not to blame African slaves. In addition, there are no historical grounds—I'm not an expert myself, but I have consulted one expert on these matters. I've read more than one— there are no historical grounds for the claim that African chiefs generally opposed the slave trade. None. And that while it is possible that some chiefs felt themselves compelled by Europeans to raid for slaves, many of them were engaged in slave trading and raiding for centuries before Europeans arrived in the scene. There were African slaves being traded by Arabs into the Muslim world. Before that, African slaves were being traded into the Roman world for centuries.
- 5.32** On the issue of the extent to which Britain's wealth and power was built on the slave trade and slavery, Beckles is unequivocal. He says, "It's important for British society to acknowledge that its development as a nation state, the transformation of its economy

to sustainable industrialization, and its global standing as a superpower among nations were founded upon a crime against humanity," that phrase again, "in the form of racial chattel enslavement of African bodies and the global trafficking of these bodies for 300 years." 300 years? 150.

- 5.33** In adopting this view, Beckles declares himself, particularly indebted to Eric Williams, whom we met earlier. He's aware that Williams' thesis in *Capitalism and Slavery* has been criticized, and he says, "Conservative economic historians launched a crusade against it," then comments, "in most cases, there were layers of ideology distinctly Eurocentric and sometimes with racial undertones." Nevertheless, he argues that the continued capacity of Williams' thesis to stimulate further research suggests its "essential correctness."
- 5.34** In defense of his position, he invokes the Marxist tradition of British historiography with its leading lights, Eric Hobsbawm and Christopher Hill. "Such scholars," he tells us, "have tended to treat the issues raised by Williams more fairly." In addition to Marxist historians, Beckles also enlists some critics of Williams. He refers to the ardent critic David Richardson, who, according to Beckles, argues that Richardson essentially "agreed with the fundamental correctness of Williams' research." And summarizing Kenneth Morgan's position, he writes for Morgan, "the slavery system wasn't the cause of British development, it was a stimulus." And he says, "Williams wouldn't have disagreed." So Beckles tries to invoke some critics of Williams in Beckles' own case.
- 5.35** But the argument that Beckles makes, I think, is just riddled with problems. First of all, he doesn't engage at all with the conservative economic historians who disagreed with Williams. He doesn't even name them. He just dismisses their views as distorted by political ideology, unlike Beckles, and by racism. Second, the works of recognized experts on transatlantic slavery, such as David Eltis, Seymour Drescher, and David Brion Davis, do appear in Beckles' bibliography but received no mention at all in text. It was Davis, you may remember, who declared of Eric Williams' thesis in 2010 that it has, "now been wholly discredited by other scholars."
- 5.36** Third, Beckles identifies himself with a Marxist-Leninist reading of colonial economics, which hasn't fared well, generally speaking, when brought into contact with historical data. Fourth, his claim that Richardson and Morgan end up confirming Williams' thesis is just not true. That thesis was not that the profits from the slave trade were merely an economic stimulus, no one denies that, but that they made an enormous contribution to Britain's industrial development. That's Beckles' position, too. Whereas Richardson says that slavery and the slave trade made a contribution of around 12%, which is significant but not enormous. And Morgan reckons that it would be incorrect to claim that the profits from the trade were a major stimulus for industrialization in Britain. Fifth and finally, Beckles is completely oblivious to the century and a half of what happened after the slave trade was abolished. A century and a half of worldwide suppression of slavery by the British Empire.

- 5.37 Notwithstanding the implausibility of Beckles' case, I don't mean to say that there are no colonial cases closely analogous to that of the Nazi theft of Jewish property. That's to say, where it's clear that a just law or treaty was broken, what right was violated, who held the right, who are the descendants of the right-holder, and who should make good the loss. In such cases, restitution or reparation would make sense. However, many, perhaps most cases where native peoples now assert historic rights to land allegedly stolen from their ancestors are not of that kind. The rights they assert are not legal but moral. They can't be legal because when Europeans first arrived on the native shores, there was no international law that fixed what the native peoples held and what the migrants could claim by legal right. But to talk of non-conventional natural moral rights misleads because the very concept of a right, being originally legal, implies a fixity that doesn't exist.
- 5.38 I think we should jettison here of talk of rights in such cases and talk of justice instead. But justice varies according to circumstances. What is just in an abundant environment with a small population is not just in the same environment with a large population or depleted resources. Justice varies according to circumstance. What this means is that even if there was an injustice done in the past, reversing it may not achieve justice in the present.
- 5.39 For example, the historic theft of land meant a gravity of loss to my ancestor in 1800, that it can't mean for me in 2020, now that I'm supported by a welfare state. Certainly these are very different. Similarly, if you now sit on the land stolen from my ancestor, simply returning it to me would do you an injustice insofar as you've built a life and an economy on it, and they're not blameable for the original wrong. The legal philosopher, Jeremy Waldron, says this: "There have been huge changes since North America and Australasia were settled by white colonists. The population has increased manyfold, and most of the descendants of the colonists, unlike their ancestors, have nowhere else to go. The changes that have taken place over the past 200 years mean that the costs of respecting primeval entitlements are much greater now than they were in 1800."
- 5.40 Besides, trying to respect alleged primeval entitlements by rolling time backwards and restoring Aboriginal land and self-government doesn't always benefit the native peoples. There are some in Canada who argue that such a policy continues to keep, "Natives isolated and dependent, thus perpetuating existing social pathologies and has resulted in a large amount of corruption where powerful families siphon off most of the resources while the majority remain mired in poverty and social dysfunction. Privileged leaders live in luxury and are paid huge salaries while most Aboriginal people rely on social assistance."
- 5.41 Now, that's just one opinion. But the argument is that trying to reverse history and go back to where things were 200 years ago doesn't always result actually in the benefit to native peoples. In the face of these intractable complications, Waldron concludes—and I agree with him—that our focus should lie on addressing present injustices, present

inequalities, rather than trying to untangle historic injustices. Waldron writes, "It is the impulse to do justice now that should lead the way, not the reparation of something whose wrongness is understood primarily in relation to conditions that no longer obtain. Entitlements fade with time. Counterfactuals are impossible to verify. Injustices are overtaken by circumstances."

- 5.42 Nonetheless, even if claims for the restitution of land or compensation for its loss are often not analogous to those of the Nazi theft of Jewish property, some may be. The same may be true of other forms of property. In such cases, restitution or reparation would be morally right. However, the problem with the most famous instance of a current claim for restitution that of the so-called Benin Bronzes, is that it is motivated by moral guilt inspired by a decolonizing distortion of colonial history.
- 5.43 The main purveyor of the distorted history is Dan Hicks, author of a book entitled *The Brutish Museums: The Benin Bronzes, Colonial Violence and Cultural Restitution*, published in 2020. The thesis of Hicks's book is that museums in Britain, and more broadly the West, are expressions of a militaristic vision of white supremacy through their unembarrassed display of colonial loot, seized by atrocious violence. The repudiation of white supremacist racism, therefore, demands the return of stolen property. To substantiate his thesis, Hicks constructs a story about the events that led to the British seizure of the famous Benin bronzes. The undisputed bare bones of what happened are these.
- 5.44 In February 1897, a British naval expedition launched an attack on Benin City in West Africa, the capital of the Edo people. The British prevailed. Most of the city was burned to the ground, and at least 2,000 major "objets d'art"—artifacts—were taken away. Among these were the bronzes, plaques depicting the history of the Royal Court of Benin and cast from brass acquired through the sale of slaves. In the aftermath, a form of indirect colonial rule was imposed and the Kingdom of Benin was incorporated into what was then the British Niger Coast Protectorate, the NCP. The prevalent Victorian explanation was that the military operation was a punitive expedition, launched in retaliation for the massacre the previous month of a diplomatic mission, whose nine white members, led by acting consul James Phillips, had been deliberately unarmed apart from revolvers, which were stowed away. Once Benin City had been taken, regime change was justified, partly because the old regime had been bound up with religious practices that included human sacrifice as well as with slavery.
- 5.45 Against this, Dan Hicks launches his anti-Western counter-narrative. The British, he claims, had been planning to invade Benin for years. While their pretext was humanitarian, the real motive was economic. The Oba, or King, of Benin had been obstructing trade, and his kingdom sat on rich resources of timber. The diplomatic mission may have been armed, Hicks claims. The invasion itself used ultraviolence, shelling villages indiscriminately and slaughtering tens of thousands. As for the bronzes, they were looted.

- 5.46 Hicks' thinking displays symptoms of an ethical schizophrenia. On the one hand, morally neutral and indulgent toward non-Western African culture. On the other hand, morally absolutist and unforgiving toward Western British culture. The indulgence is evident in his treatment of human sacrifice in Benin, to which he pays almost no attention. On one occasion, he nonchalantly admits that it might have happened, but only to brush it aside so that he can focus our attention on British atrocities. Otherwise, he consistently insinuates that the reports were made-up fantasies.
- 5.47 But there is no reasonable doubt that human sacrifice did take place in Benin. Indeed, there was a substantial increase in its scale from the 1830s to the 1880s. Whereas the balm of indulgence is given to the Edo, the acid of cynicism is poured over the British. The abolition of the slave trade and slavery in the British Empire receives no credit. Indeed, it is discredited through its use as what Hicks calls "a human rightist justification for unprovoked regime change." The possibility that the eradication of African slavery might ever have required and justified British domination is just never considered.
- 5.48 In the light of these axioms, when Hicks turns to British action regarding Benin, he argues three things. First, the punitive expedition in February 1897 was not in fact retaliatory since preparations for an attack on Benin were already underway by the autumn of the previous year. As evidence, he invokes the arrival of military officers participating in a Royal Niger Company expedition against a then-unidentified target on the Niger River in November '96. The two operations he claims were a joint action of the company and the Niger Coast Protectorate. How do we know this? Well, in part because the NCP's Consul General and the RNC's governor met in London at the end of 1896. He doesn't tell us what they talked about. What he does do is to cite Robert Home's book in support. But if you go to the relevant page in Home, Home makes quite clear that the Consul General and the governor did not regard themselves as allies. They were bitter rivals. So was there coordination/cooperation? It's not clear.
- 5.49 Hicks' second argument is that the members of Phillips' January expedition were possibly armed and their deaths were only a supposed massacre. The white man, he says, reportedly took only revolvers. He appeals to a Daily Mail report, a press report suggesting that the expedition had offered a stout resistance and also to a published recollection of a witness soon after of a mile of road strewn with bodies at the site. Hicks thinks this could be evidence of a sustained two-way exchange rather than the widespread slaughter of unarmed carriers. So he wants to suggest, "No, the expedition wasn't unarmed. There might have been actually a two-way violent exchange."
- 5.50 The problem is that first-hand testimony is unanimously against Hicks because there were two survivors of the massacre. One of them, a Captain Boisragon, wrote that "we were not carrying revolvers because the revolvers were all locked up in boxes." Now, that's a white man's testimony, but here comes a black person's testimony. Boisragon's testimony was confirmed by a second-hand account of the trial of those suspected of

responsibility for the attack on Phillips, which reported that the three African witnesses for the prosecution, "all acknowledged that they knew beforehand that all the white men were unarmed."

- 5.51** Hicks' third main line of argument is that in the course of sacking Benin, the British perpetrated atrocious violence and looting. He's disturbed by the vast asymmetry of military power with the British using naval guns and Maxim machine guns to wreak colonial ultraviolence upon enemy armed with at best muskets. And he asserts that Edo deaths ran into tens of thousands. Hicks doesn't seem to understand that the purpose of military endeavor is precisely to subdue the enemy by overwhelming him. And as for the number of Edo casualties, he simply plucks his figure out of the unargued blue. He doesn't argue it, he just asserts it. On what happened in Benin City itself, Hicks is unequivocal. It was wantonly destroyed.
- 5.52** The fire of 21st February, which the British claimed as accidental, was in fact, he writes, "probably just one that got out of control in a mounting frenzy of demolition." Again, here he flies in the face of the only first-hand testimony we have, which tells of targeted demolition by the British for the purpose of military defense, of care taken not to start an accidental conflagration, of the intention to use the city as the seat of a new government— which if you want to use the city as a seat of a new government, you don't burn it down— and of the surprise with which the fire of 21st February struck, such as a surprise that some of those present had their clothing burnt because they couldn't remove it fast enough. It seems to me clear from the evidence that Benin did burn, but it wasn't sacked. The fire was accidental.
- 5.53** As for the bronzes, these were removed as spoils of war, but this wasn't looting, understood as the unauthorized seizure of items for private purposes by troops running amok because that was outlawed sold by British military law. At Benin, the British commander took care to reserve all the major items as government property. Removed to London, some items were distributed as prizes among the naval officers, according to custom, but most were auctioned by the admiralty. We don't quite know how the proceeds were spent, but there's reason to suppose they were used to defray the expedition's costs, which included pensions for the wounded and the bereaved.
- 5.54** In sum, a scrupulous reading of the data supports the following narrative, I suggest. Both European and African traders were frustrated by the Oba of Benin's unpredictable closing of markets, and they pressed the British authorities to intervene. Yet commercial interests were never simply commercial because the promotion of legitimate commerce had been long viewed as a means of displacing the slave trade. Initially, the British tried diplomacy and signed a treaty with the Oba in 1892, committing him to permit free trade. When this proved ineffective, one official on the ground, Ralph Moor, lobbied for military action. Yet the London government remained skeptical and cautious, and in December 1896, it prevaricated. London governments on the whole did not like to intervene because it cost money.

- 5.55** The slaughter of Phillips' unarmed mission in January '97, however, forced London's hand to authorize a punitive expedition. So when they went to war in February 1897, the British intended primarily to retaliate for the massacre in order to maintain their regional authority and deter any repetition. The enabling of free trade and the ending of the practices of slavery and human sacrifice were secondary intentions. Here we have, again, a number of different motives and intentions in play, and the humanitarian ones were secondary, but they weren't insincere. By the first of April, 1897, the new British resident had proclaimed that any slave who arrived in the deserted city before his master would become free, persuading many slaves to rush back. And by the 18th of May, the British resident had prohibited slave trading in the markets of Benin City.
- 5.56** If there are good reasons for British museums and other owners to return Benin bronzes to Benin now, I submit that colonial guilt is not among them. Because the bronzes themselves were cast from a form of currency used by the Beninese to trade slaves. And among the motives for the British invasion were the emancipation of slaves and the ending of human sacrifice. What's more, the bronzes were not looted but removed as spoils of war to defray the cost of the expedition and support the wounded and bereaved. The British were really not so brutish in Benin.
- 5.57** So to conclude: should the British pay reparations or make restitution for the evils of colonialism? Well, if there are particular cases closely analogous to the nasty theft of Jewish property, the answer would be yes. But as the passage of time between the present and the colonial past increases, as the original perpetrators and victims fade into oblivion, and as the fact to determining the fate of their descendants, multiply and interact, those cases become vanishingly rare. Moreover, the British owe no overall apology for their colonial endeavors in general. Since many of those were innocent, some actively intended good, and some actually achieved it. The data of history do not support any generalized colonial guilt. Thus, the basic motive to which the cultural revolutionary decolonizing story appeals for reparations is, I suggest, without ground.
- 5.58** As with my previous lectures, much of this lecture has been taken from my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*, from Chapter 8 and the conclusion, and you can refer to those if you want to explore the issues more deeply.

Lecture 6: Reevaluating Decolonization

At a glance — The closing lecture reevaluates decolonization as a movement: which of its aims are reasonable, which overreach, and why Biggar regards its more sweeping claims as historically distorting and politically risky for Western societies.

- 6.1 Welcome back to this course of lectures, Deconstructing Decolonization, and welcome to this 6th and final lecture, which has the title: On Decolonizing Motives. In this series of lectures, I've sought to deconstruct decolonization, to distinguish versions that make more or less good sense from those that make more or less bad sense. And early on, identified the worst version as the cultural revolutionary one. And since then, I sought to lay bare the falsity of its main claims. In this concluding lecture, I will examine what it is that propels the decolonizers to make so many claims that run ahead of reason and evidence. I will seek to answer the question: What motivates them?
- 6.2 Not every contemporary critic of Western colonialism is propelled by humanitarian motives. The Chinese Communist Party, for example, likes to beat the drum about China's 100 years of humiliation at the hands of Western powers, especially the British Empire, in order to obscure the massive homegrown horrors of Chairman Mao's great leap forward and cultural revolution, to excite nationalist feeling in China, and to manipulate liberal guilt abroad in the service of a brutally aggressive foreign policy. In contrast, the anticolonists in today's West—whether postcolonialist academics or decolonizing activists—are apparently motivated by righteous anger at the demeaning and oppressive racism that they believe structures Western societies because of the toxic legacy of their colonial past.
- 6.3 In the course of these lectures, I have sought to show that this belief is false in every one of its parts. Britain today is not systemically racist. Indeed, it is one of the least racist countries in Europe, quite possibly the world. That's not to say that Britain doesn't contain racism. Slavery was not the epitome of the British Empire. On the contrary, it was among the first states in the history of the world to repudiate slavery in the name of a Christian vision of basic human equality. From 1807, during the second half of its life, it was centrally committed to emancipating non-white slaves from the West Indies and Brazil, across Africa to India and Australasia.
- 6.4 Partly for that reason, and partly because the Empire spent itself in opposing the murderously racist Nazi regime during the Second World War, in which from May 1940 to June 1941, it offered the only military opposition apart from Greece. For those reasons, it cannot fairly be said that the Empire was essentially racist, even if it did contain lamentable elements of racism. Further, the Empire's consistent policy of cultural assimilation was intended to rescue, not destroy native peoples and did not amount to genocide. And the British today do not have a duty as a rule to make reparations to the descendants of those who suffered evils under British colonial government.

- 6.5 The decolonizing critics of colonialism cannot be blamed for condemning racism or slavery and the indiscriminate suppression of native cultures. I condemn them, too. But they can be blamed for letting their condemnations run way out ahead of the historical data. In these lectures, I've shown a number of critics overegging the sins of British colonialism, most notably the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada on the residential school system in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, Hilary Beckles on the slave trade and slavery in the West Indies, and Dan Hicks on the 1897 invasion of Benin. In my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*, I document many, many more instances of the same overreaching phenomenon. The very first occasion I became aware of the willfully cavalier treatment of colonial history by decolonizers was during the first Rhodes Must Fall campaign in Oxford. In the autumn of 2015, some students began to agitate to have an obscure statue of Cecil Rhodes removed from its plinth overlooking Oxford's High Street.
- 6.6 The case against Rhodes was that he was South Africa's equivalent of Hitler, and the supporting evidence was encapsulated in this damning statement— this is supposed to be a quotation of Rhodes—and it runs, "I prefer land to 'the N-word.' The natives are like children. They are just emerging from barbarism. One should kill as many 'the N-word' as possible." The case for Rhodes doesn't look good, given that statement. But research has discovered that the Rhodes Must Fall campaigners had lifted this quotation verbatim from a book review by Adekeye Adebajo, a former Rhodes Scholar who is now Director of the Institute for Pan-African Thought and Conversation at the University of Johannesburg. And further digging revealed that the so-called quotation was in fact made up of three different elements, drawn from three different sources. The first had been lifted from a novel. The other two had been misleadingly torn out of their proper context, and part of the third appears to be made up.
- 6.7 There's no doubt that the real Rhodes was a moral mixture, but he wasn't Hitler. Far from being racist, he showed consistent sympathy for individual black Africans throughout his life. In an 1894 speech, he made plain his view, "I do not believe that they are different (they, the Africans), are different from ourselves." Nor did he attempt genocide against the Southern African Ndebele people in 1896, as might be suggested by the fact that the Ndebele tended his grave from 1902 for decades. He had nothing at all to do with General Kitchener's infamous concentration camps during the Second Boer War of 1899-1902, which themselves had nothing morally in common with Auschwitz.
- 6.8 Moreover, Rhodes did support a franchise in Cape Colony that gave black Africans the vote on the same terms as whites. He helped to finance a black African newspaper, and he established his famous scholarship scheme, which was explicitly color-blind and whose first black American beneficiary was selected within five years of his death.
- 6.9 However—and this is my point—none of these historical details seem to matter to the student activists, baying for Rhodes' downfall, or to the professional academics who

supported them. The truth about the past didn't seem to matter. Why do I say this? Well, I published an extended expression of my view of Rhodes—a 4,000-word article, complete with evidence and argument in March 2016. In a slightly right-of-center monthly current affairs journal. And since then, no one has offered me a considered critical response. I said what I thought, and I'm waiting for a response. And until someone shows me I'm wrong, I assume I'm right.

- 6.10** But when the Rhodes Must Fall campaign revived four years later in the wake of the Black Lives Matter movement, the same old false allegations arrived with it, utterly unchastened. So in the Guardian newspaper, an Oxford doctoral student and former editor of the Oxford University Commonwealth Law Journal, was still slandering Rhodes as a genocidaire—as genocidal— in June 2020. The truth made no difference.
- 6.11** As to why the condemnations have exceeded the evidence, as to their propelling motives, we can only speculate. But speculation can be more or less informed and more or less reasonable. There's no doubt that in some cases, material political interests have been active. Hilary Beckles' book, for example, is an argument for reparations that invokes leading members of Britain's Labour Party at the beginning of over half its chapters. It 's a manifesto for making claims politically. In other cases, mundane professional interests have no doubt played a part. Like most other people, typical academics just want to get on in life, advance their careers, and pay the mortgage. While they may be independently minded in the narrow field of their own academic expertise, generally speaking, they are perfectly capable of behaving like sheep. Indeed, since all they have to sell are their reputations, it may be that academics probably care more than most about how their peers view them and are therefore more than usually inclined to let themselves be carried by the winds of prevailing fashion.
- 6.12** That may go some way to explain why in 1930s Germany, support for the Nazi Party was much higher in universities than in the rest of the electorate, and vocal opposition from university professors was almost nonexistent. Certainly, in my own experience, academics have no special endowment of moral courage. They may be no worse than other people, but they're not especially courageous, and they're not extraordinarily inclined to suffer the social and professional costs of standing out and being dissident. So observing that decolonization is fashionable, opening doors to posts, promotions, and grants, and observing that the merest skepticism is enough to chill the air around them, many academics will be content to go with the flow, virtue-signaling their subscription to the correct assumptions. And that will be true in spades of younger scholars of the humanities who are struggling to launch their careers in an environment where hundreds of PhDs are chasing a handful of tenure-track positions.
- 6.13** Yet there's more to the motivation of decolonization and decolonizers than mere material and professional interests because those don't explain the intemperate, nasty,

ad personam hostility that many decolonizers are wont to show dissenters. Again, I know this from my own experience.

- 6.14** Priyamvada Gopal, the Cambridge University professor of postcolonial studies, who concerted the three online denunciations of my Ethics and Empire Project back in December 2017, has written in public that my scholarship is "supremacist shite, " that I'm a "racist and a bigot"—my name Biggar helps with that—and that whatever comes out of my mouth is "vomit." I know this. I can show you the screenshots of the tweets.
- 6.15** And in 2019, Richard Drayton, a professor of history at King's College in London, devoted a whole chapter of a book to analyzing the "Biggar phenomenon" as a sign of the times. And while I find the importance he attributes to me to be flattering, the manner in which he treated me was certainly not, as I wrote in my online riposte. If you want to see what he wrote, it's published on the King's College London website, so you can judge whether what I'm about to say is fair or not.
- 6.16** But here's my summary of what he wrote. "Drayton's thinking has taken the form of a false interpretation of data, several gratuitous and malicious ad hominem insinuations, a host of misrepresentations, the pulling of professional rank, irrelevant pedantry, distorting caricatures, and a complete failure to engage carefully and rationally with what I actually say. Thereby, it's given expression to the following intellectual vices: carelessness, injustice, uncharity, hubris, and evasiveness. Evidently, these are motivated by a zealous political hostility that so robs him, that so possesses him as to rob him of reason and scrupul. This zeal will not brook contradiction. It won't entertain the possibility that it might be mistaken. So instead of letting a contrary position stand, observing it carefully, doing it justice, and letting it provoke thought, which risks giving rise to doubt, it has to be manhandled into the shape of a risible straw man to be brushed aside with ease."
- 6.17** That's my summary of what I thought of what Drayton wrote. But this is the point. Both those cases and others raise the question of: Why? What gives rise to the vices, to this refusal to think, and to the hostility, and the consequent injustice? When such people hear what I have to say, I understand they may not like it. I understand they may disagree with it. They could respond with a kind of skeptical curiosity, "W hy on earth would you think that? What are your reasons? Haven't you noticed A, B, and C?" The response could be robust curiosity. But it's not curiosity I meet with, it's aggression. Why? Where's the aggression coming from?
- 6.18** I think the springs of—at least some in my experience—quite a bit of decolonizing motivation are deeper, even darker, than material and professional interests. Whatever they are, it seems they're not new. 60 years ago, in 1962, the French Catholic philosopher Gabriel Marcel, observed the tendency of the political left to manipulate colonial history to suit its ideological prejudices, driven by what he calls a passion, a hidden passion. And he wrote, "I consider the man of the left to be almost always someone who treats the past very casually and who, in particular, does not hesitate to

manipulate it according to a number of preformed ideas. I find this extremely clear, for example, with regard to the problem of colonization." Remember, we're talking 60 years ago, he was saying this. "What strikes me about the man of the left is a certain lack of reflection, with exceptions, of course. The great danger which threatens him is to succumb to the mirage of ideology. What I often discover in him is a kind of abstract thought, which is in reality at the service of a passion that can't be confessed."

- 6.19** That seems correct. Beyond the interests here, there is a passion at work, or maybe even several passions. But what are they? Well, one obvious candidate is the familiar human pleasure of crusading. I presume that we all know about this because we all engaged in it. The pleasure of knowing that one's in the right, of occupying the moral high ground and casting the wicked down it. It's quite fun and very satisfying. We all know, I think, the attractions of riding a moral high horse, playing the knight in shining armor. But the dangers of such crusading are also familiar, are they not? The ugly arrogance of self-righteousness, impervious to correction, and productive of high-handed abuse, even to the point of atrocity. Decolonizers readily recognize this in colonialists, but never in themselves. Sin always lies over there.
- 6.20** One rationale for this moral, even spiritual, attitude lies in the idea that the views and feelings of the oppressed and those who presume to represent them are the first and last word, the final authority. They speak a truth that can't be gainsaid. Their lived experience is the first and last word, the final authority. Earlier in discussion after one of my earlier lectures, one of you was talking about "my truth" — a notion that I possess a truth that is my property in the sense you can't do about that. It's just mine. I possess it. You can't criticize it. It's mine. It's my lived experience. You can't contradict it because it's deeply lived. I tried to suggest in an earlier lecture that no experience, however visceral, however deeply felt, is based on perceptions. A perception can be wrong, and the perceptions can be challenged. Still, the argument here is the lived experience of the oppressed is the final authority.
- 6.21** You can find a seminal expression of this in a classic postcolonial text, Frantz Fanon's *The Wretched of the Earth*. Born in Martinique in 1925, Fanon had studied medicine in France, specializing in psychiatry, and was working in a hospital in Algeria when the nationalist uprising against the French erupted in 1954. The following year, he himself joined the anticolonial rebels. Not long afterwards, however, he was diagnosed with leukemia, and having traveled to Bethesda, Maryland, for medical treatment, he died there in 1961. Shortly before his death, he dictated and published *Les Damnés De La Terre*, *The Wretched of the Earth*, for which the French philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre wrote a preface, and which went on to make a deep impression on the leadership of the Black Power Movement in the United States.
- 6.22** In one passage of *The Wretched of the Earth*, Fanon asserts the view that the nationalist revolutionaries are the privileged possessors of the truth, our truth. And he writes, "The community triumphs, and it spreads its own light and its own reason. Truth

is the property of the national cause. The native replies to the living lie of the colonial situation by an equal falsehood. Truth is that which hurries on the breakup of the colonialist regime. It is that which promotes the emergence of the nation. It is also all that protects the natives and ruins the foreigners. In this colonialist context, there is no truthful behavior, and the good is quite simply that which is evil for them. Thus, we see the primary Manichaeism which governed colonial society is preserved intact during the period of decolonization. That is to say that the settler never ceases to be the enemy, the opponent, the foe that must be overthrown."

- 6.23** As the needs of revolutionary liberation determine the truth, so black vitality throws off the shackles of European reason. He continues, "The concept of Negroism," the French word is *negritude*, "The concept of Negroism—blackness— was the emotional, if not the logical antithesis of that insult which the white man flung at humanity. The unconditional affirmation of African culture has succeeded the unconditional affirmation of European culture. On the whole, the poets of Negroism oppose the idea of old Europe to a young Africa, tiresome reasoning to lyricism, oppressive logic to high stepping nature, and on the one side, stiffness, ceremony, etiquette, and skepticism while on the other, frankness, liveliness, liberty, and, why not, luxuriance, but also, irresponsibility. In order to ensure his salvation and to escape from the supremacy of the white man's culture, the native feels the need to turn backwards toward his unknown roots and to lose himself at whatever cost in his own barbarous people."
- 6.24** Whatever its merits in restoring the self-respect of the colonized, this view amounts to a dogmatic revolutionary authoritarianism that dismisses contradictory reasons as reactionary rationalizations. More deeply, I think it amounts to a demonic spirituality. Because the person who embodies the revolutionary truth is subject to no higher law because he is the law. He is a little God unto himself. And little gods are dangerous because their erroneous truths can't be corrected. And because their chosen treatment of others recognizes no external constraints. Little gods wreak havoc with humanity. Think Stalin's purges of 1936- 8, Mao's Cultural Revolution of 1966-76, and Pol Pot's Killing Fields of 1975-09.
- 6.25** Fanon's own work gives evidence of a causal connection between revolutionary self-righteousness and the cavalier treatment of historical evidence. Because alongside his assertion that truth is whatever serves the revolution, we find generalizations about European colonialism that owe much more to ideological axioms than to a disciplined observation of historical data—much more to theory than to data. Thus, he claims, that European wealth, "It has been founded on slavery. It has been nourished with the blood of slaves, and it comes directly from the soil and from the subsoil of that underdeveloped world." Yet my discussion of Eric Williams' Marxist thesis in my second lecture, has shown, I think, that this is very probably untrue.
- 6.26** Next, Fanon writes that the colonial regime owes its legitimacy to force. "When in laying down precise methods, the settler asks each member of the oppressing minority

to shoot down 30, or 100, or 200 natives. He sees that nobody shows any indignation, that the whole problem is to decide whether it can be done at all at once or by stages." In my discussion of colonial government in chapter 7 of my book on colonialism makes clear that its legitimacy also usually rested on native cooperation, by no means all of it coerced. My discussion of settler violence in chapter 5 of that book showed that not even in Tasmania were settlers generally disposed to slaughter—exterminate the Aboriginals. Regarding the Mau Mau Uprising in Kenya in the 1950s, Fanon talks of the 200,000 victims of the repression. It's not clear that by victims here, he means fatalities. But since the other two cases he mentions in the same sentence do concern fatalities—the 45,000 dead at Setif, the 90,000 dead at Madagascar—the impression lingers that the Kenyan victims, the 200,000 victims, were killed. In fact, those killed by the security forces in the emergency in Kenya numbered somewhere between 11,500-20,000. That is between 5.75% and 10% of Fanon's figure.

- 6.27 Finally, he claims that colonialism, which "turns to the past of the oppressed people and distorts, disfigures, and destroys it, resulted in cultural obliteration." Yet, as I reported in my third lecture, David Gilmour makes clear that, for example, in the case of India, ancient Hindu culture was rescued from oblivion, not obliterated, by British Orientalists, and the same is true in Java.
- 6.28 The lack of historical scrupulousness can reasonably be attributed to the idea that truth is whatever the decolonizing revolution requires and that revolutionary vitality should be preferred to bourgeois reason. For those ideas make of history no longer an authority that constrains what may be claimed, but merely an armory to be ransacked in the interest of rhetorical advantage. The past is just weaponry. Because we know what the truth is. Such an attitude has certainly been visible among the supporters of Rhodes Must Fall, in particular, and of decolonization in general.
- 6.29 Symptoms have also appeared among some of the historians we've encountered. The problem with it is that it renders entirely unaccountable the revolutionary's own assumptions and choice of means, placing them safely beyond criticism. The problem is that it is authoritarian. Even worse, in Fanon's case, this authoritarianism acquired fascistic qualities. He shared Sartre's fascination with the cathartic cleansing power of revolutionary violence. "Decolonization is the veritable creation of new men. The last shall be first and the first last. Decolonization is the putting into practice of this sentence: This will only come to pass after a murderous and decisive struggle. This narrow colonial world can only be turned upside down by absolute violence. The colonized man finds his freedom in and through violence.
- 6.30 The poetry of Aimé Césaire takes on in this precise aspect of violence a prophetic significance. We may recall one of the most decisive pages of his tragedy where the rebel explains his conduct. The rebel says, "I struck and the blood spurted. That is the only baptism I remember today." "For the native," Fanon writes, "life can only spring up again out of the rotting corpse of the settler." Given this almost aesthetic fascination

with violence and the preference for barbarous fatality—that was the word he used, "barbarous fatality"—and irresponsibility over civilized European reason and restraint, the German ancient historian, Egon Flaig, was not being sensationalist, I think, when he described Fanon's decolonization as "fascistoid", meaning a akin to fascism. That kinship seems all the stronger in the light of Joachim Fest's account of what made German intellectuals so prone to Nazism, namely a cultural process, "in the course of which the mind turned away from itself in the name of a philosophy of life, of the will to power, of rough dynamic vitality, and continually renounced the European rationalist tradition.

- 6.31 The influence of authority and ideas like Frantz Fanon's goes some way to explaining the tendency of many decolonizers to treat historical data as political ammunition rather than intellectual constraints, and to propel the indictment of colonialism well beyond the evidence. Certainly, moral political dogmatism is characteristic of the discipline—if discipline is the apt word—of postcolonialist studies.
- 6.32 In his introduction to the Oxford Handbook on the subject, Graham Huggan describes postcolonialism as, "...a committed mode of knowledge that dedicates itself to the service of human freedom in the context of a world historically conditioned by colonial relations of power." Yet the typical laborer in the postcolonialist fields is neither a philosopher equipped to interrogate concepts such as freedom and power, nor an ethicist equipped to evaluate them morally, nor an historian equipped to enter sympathetically into the strange world of the past.
- 6.33 Usually, the postcolonialist is a scholar of literature. Accordingly, literature furnished 24 of the 44 contributors to the Oxford Handbook, history only 4, and philosophy, a mere 1. The typical postcolonialist scholar of literature takes her bearings not from historical data, but wholesale from postmodern theorists for whom the injustice of colonialism is axiomatic. It 's assumed rather than demonstrated. As Huggan says, " The colonizer versus the colonized is the field's formative binary." I guess what he means by it is it's an axiomatic opposition. Axiomatic means it's basic, no one questions it, we just assume it.
- 6.34 It shouldn't surprise, therefore, to find the historian Stephen Howe reporting that, "Most contemporary historians of empire have tended to identify postcolonial cultural theories with an alleged disregard for historical specificity and precision." Howe uses the word alleged. I would take it out. Then he comments, "There was, it must be recognized, considerable warrant for such charges in the work of some of the key early postcolonialists. Too often, a hand of isolated colonial texts or incidents served as rather perfunctory prefaces to far -reaching declarations about a generalized colonial situation." So there he's confirming my perception of overreach, going beyond the evidence of the data.
- 6.35 And he says, "Three of the essential keywords of historical and social scientific discourse seemed disconcertingly absent—evidence, context, and explanation." In the

light of what I have seen myself and some of what I've reported in these lectures, what Howe says was true of early postcolonialists remains true of contemporary decolonizers. The sinful human pleasure of godlike self-righteous crusading, buttressed by antirational vitalist authoritarian theory, goes a long way, I think, in identifying the passion that drives decolonizers to propel their critique of colonial endeavor way out in front of the historical data.

- 6.36** But there's still more to the decolonizing overreach than that. Many of those who indict the European, British, or American colonial pasts are themselves European, British, or American. Now, I agree that to condemn one's own people might well be right, but also to be painful. Usually painful to acknowledge one's own personal fault. If you identify with the people, it's painful to acknowledge that one's people has been wrong. It may be right to do it, but it should be painful. One surely wouldn't choose to do it unless you felt it necessary. Yet I observe the exaggeration of colonialism's sins by these European, British, and American decolonizers is usually not at all reluctant, but willful, even gleeful. Far from being resisted, it's embraced. The decolonizers want the worst to be true. That's why when met with any suggestion to the contrary, they respond not with the eyes of curiosity, but the fist of no-holds-barred aggression. But again, why? What's going on here, psychologically, indeed, spiritually?
- 6.37** One candidate that seems to me plausible is the operation of a degenerate Christian sensibility. For Christians, the paradoxical mark of the genuinely righteous person is a profound awareness of their own unrighteousness. The saint is distinguished as one who knows more deeply than others just what a sinner he really is. And there is considerable virtue in this, of course, because it tempers self-righteousness with compassion for fellow sinners, forbidding the righteous to cast the unrighteous beyond the human pale. So whatever you do wrong to me, if I remember I'm a sinner, I have to remember that you and I have something in common. We both do wrong. So I can't damn you absolutely. My damnation is restrained. But like all virtue, this awareness of one's own sinfulness, one's own unrighteousness, is vulnerable to vice, because it can degenerate from genuine humility into a perverse bid for supreme self-righteousness, which exaggerates one's sins and broadcasts the display of repentance—holier than thou, because more sinful than thou.
- 6.38** The Jesuit-educated French philosopher, Pascal Bruckner, captures this when he writes of contemporary post-imperial Europe. And he says, "This is the paternalism of the guilty conscience. Seeing ourselves as the kings of infamy is still a way of staying on the crest of history. Since Freud, we know that masochism is only a reverse sadism, a passion for domination turned against oneself. Europe is still messianic in a minor key. Barbarity is Europe's great pride, which it acknowledges only in itself. It denies that others are barbarous, finding attenuating circumstances for them, which is a way of denying them all responsibility."

- 6.39 There is, I observe, a self-obsessive quality to this attitude. While the decolonizing rhetoric claims the mantle of the oppressed, the action of the decolonizers ignores them. Accordingly, highly privileged students and professors gather in the streets of Oxford to clamor for the downfall of an obscure statue of a British imperialist who died in Cape Town well over a century ago. Meanwhile, in today's South Africa, the African National Congress loots the state, triples unemployment, sharpens economic inequality, and riots when its leader is sentenced to jail for refusing to answer charges of corruption. And yet the Oxford protestors are silent. They fiddle in Oxford while Africa burns. Bruckner captures this point, too. "By erecting lack of love for oneself into a leading principle, we lie to ourselves about ourselves and close ourselves to others. In Western self-hatred, the other has no place. It is a narcissistic relationship in which the African, the Indian, and Arab are brought in as extras." Remember Dan Hicks' account of Benin, the wicked white colonialist fills center stage, entirely obscuring black agency, and the white decolonizer gets to play champion of the oppressed.
- 6.40 The cultural revolutionary decolonizing story is not a reliable guide to Britain's colonial past, which is a proxy for the record of the West. Therefore, it encourages us to draw the wrong lessons for the future. If it were true that the record of Britain's 300-year career of using its imperial power to shape the world was, at base, a litany of slavery, racism, and cultural genocide, then contemporary Britons would be fully justified in adopting Sartre's cynical view of Europe's liberal and humanitarian pretensions. In his preface to Fanon's *Wretched of the Earth*, Sartre wrote of European colonial endeavor that, "Our humanism was nothing but an ideology of lies, a perfect justification for pillage. The European has only been able to become a man through creating slaves and monsters. In the notion of the human race, we found an abstract assumption of universality which served as cover for the most realistic practices. We had no mission at all," says Sartre.
- 6.41 If that were true of Europe and Britain, it would also be true of the United States, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, in all of which people of European stock were active agents of colonial expansion and rule. That's to say, it would be true of the West as a whole, in which case the West and its vaunted values would lose all credit and faith in them would lose all ground. With that faith would banish any lingering ambition to promote Western values around the world, to defend them with military force, or even to criticize how other peoples choose to conduct their own political affairs or even their own social affairs.
- 6.42 If the decolonizing narrative were true, Britain and the rest of the world should become what Pascal Bruckner fears Europe is already on the verge of becoming. As he explains, "The duty to repent forbids the Western bloc, which is eternally guilty, to judge or combat other systems, other states, other religions. Our past crimes command us to keep our mouth closed. Reserve and neutrality will redeem us. No longer participating, no longer getting involved in the affairs of our time, except perhaps by proving of those

whom we formerly oppressed. In this way, two different Wests will be defined. The good one, that of the old Europe that withdraws and keeps quiet, and the bad one, that of the US that intervenes and meddles in everything. Europe is in danger of becoming the Pontius Pilot of nations. On the whole, the old world prefers guilt to responsibility."

- 6.43 However, as I have argued in these lectures, the cultural revolutionary decolonizing narrative is not true. Yes, the British Empire contained evils and injustices, some of them very grave, some of them culpable, but so does the history of any long-standing state. Slavery was not its epitome. It was not essentially racist. It promoted cultural assimilation, primarily to rescue native peoples, not destroy them. Over time, it became increasingly motivated by Christian humanitarianism and intent upon preparing colonized peoples for liberal self-government. So if colonial history gives those of us who identify ourselves with Britain and through it, the West, cause for lament and shame, it also gives us cause for admiration and pride.
- 6.44 This is not a case of what decolonizers condescendingly dismiss as imperial nostalgia. Let me be clear: Britain's colonial moment has passed, as has Europe's, once and for all. The conditions that occasioned it will not recur again for good and for ill. So this is not about nostalgia. It's not about trying to revive the past. Rather, it is about discriminate identification with liberal humanitarian principles and endeavors of the West's colonial past that deserve to be admired, owned, and carried into the future.
- 6.45 It is about not letting what Elie Kedourie called the "canker of imaginary guilt" to cripple the self-confidence of the British, Canadians, Australians, New Zealanders, and Americans as pillars of the liberal international order. It is about maintaining faith in the West, chastened, self-critical, but faith nonetheless, by remembering what remains to its credit.
- 6.46 That brings us to the end of the series of lectures on deconstructing decolonization. This lecture has drawn heavily from the epilogue of my book, *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*, and most of the rest of the series has comprised abbreviations and excerpts of its chapters. If you want to read a full account, I commend the book to you.